

The Sport That Says Your Name: A Circulation Sport in Which Everyone Is Called by Another

sey — the Address Premise, the Impartial Caller, the Cannot-Target-Weakness Property, and Play Designed for the AI Age

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Scope and claims division (2026-07-23, first publication): this paper is the first of three published the same day. The present paper owns the **sport** — the caller mechanism and the rule architecture of *sey*, the sport the B-SeySM app and B-SeyTM ball implement. Its companion *The Wager That Isn't* owns the **challenge/stake/pot grammar** (B-MatchSM) that nests on this sport's net mode; the third, *The Game That Graduates You*, owns the **third-party game-client doctrine** (the witness API). All three share one organizing principle, coined and freed in the present paper: **the play/currency wall** — *competition and play may generate the story; only witnessed giving moves the currency*. Earlier corpus publications are cited, not re-claimed: *The Quest That Mints Nothing* owns the mints-nothing quest class; *Proof of Coordinate* owns the individuation primitive the ball's chronicle uses. At first publication the sport was specified and unbuilt, and every claim was architectural; a reference implementation has since been built (§§4.3–4.4 record two defects it surfaced). Prior art for the v1 claims dates from 2026-07-23; each later note below dates its own additions.

v2 note (2026-07-25): this revision incorporates the **2026-07-24/25 universalization** — the three axes (methods · modes · levels), the call-lead-time ladder with scaffold fading, the three-tier scoring architecture and the implied point, the two speaker formats, the local-first system architecture and the ball's reduced job, the classroom channel and the icebreaker-slot reframe, and place-sponsorship. Claims grow from ten to sixteen and pre-registrations from three to five. The v1 claims are unchanged in substance; §§3.1, 4.1, 5.1, 5.2, 7.1, 9.1, 9.2 are new, and §§11–12 are extended. The prior-art clock for the v1 claims runs from the 2026-07-23 push; for the v2 claims, from this one. (*Superseded in part on 2026-07-27 — see the note below; the two speaker formats described here became three, and the claim count moved again.*)

v3 note (2026-07-27): this revision adds the **seat taxonomy and the two delivery mechanisms that were ratified but never written**. §3 is resorted from four seats to **five, in two classes** — *determined* (caller, equalizer), whose outputs are pure functions of declared inputs and are checkable by

recomputation, and *judged* (umpire, witness), whose outputs are perceptions and are checkable only by one-sentence explanation — with the **seat-migration bar** governing both directions. New §4.2 establishes the caller as deterministic given roster and seed, from which auditable fairness, count-only multi-device agreement, and the absence of per-participant state all follow. §5.2 **grows from two speaker formats to three named ones — Relay, Call, Free** — the relay call having been absent from the specification while it was already the format intended to ship; the pilot constraint is accordingly restated by property (*a trial must run a caller-on format*) rather than by position in the list. The abstract now leads with the relay rather than the mesh, and **P-S5 gains its stated precondition** (a device available at recess, no instruction given), without which a null result cannot distinguish an unpopular game from an absent device. Claims grow from sixteen to **nineteen**. **The prior-art clock for claims 17–19 runs from this push**, not from either earlier one; §§1–11 claims are unchanged in substance.

v4 note (2026-07-27): a **title and abstract correction, no claims change**. The paper was titled "*An AI-Called Circulation Sport*" when the caller was understood as an intelligent intermediary. The v3 seat taxonomy and §4.2 established the opposite — the caller is a **determined** seat, a pure function of roster and seed, checkable by recomputation and explicitly not a judgement — with the result that the title asserted of the mechanism precisely the property the design had given up in order to make its fairness auditable. Two further readings had gone stale beneath it: the shipping delivery format (**the relay call**, claim 19) puts a *human* voice on the announcement, and the arrival of speech synthesis as a pronunciation fallback in the reference implementation gives "AI-called" an available reading — *called in a synthetic voice* — that was never its sense. The title now reads "**An Impartially-Called Circulation Sport for the AI Age**": the *property* rather than the technology, on the same reasoning §4.2 gives for determinism itself — an implementation-independent property outlives the implementation that first carried it. The abstract gains the determinism sentence that justifies the new adjective. **The coined term "AI-called circulation sport" remains coined and freed in the Prior-Art statement and is retained in the keywords**, together with the patent-class phrase §10 names — retitling does not un-free a term, and the dedication's defensive reach comes from the disclosure rather than from the title. "*For the AI Age*" is unchanged and means what it always meant: *the era whose abundances the sport is designed to spend (§1)*, not a claim about what runs the caller. Also corrected: the abstract said **sixteen** claims after the v3 pass took the count to **nineteen**.

v5 note (2026-07-27): a **change of spine, not of specification**. Through v4 the paper derived the sport from an *abundance* — machine intelligence lifting the officiating, matching, and witness scarcities under which all previous sport was designed — and the caller mechanism followed as a way to spend it. That derivation is engineering, and it left the paper unable to answer why the abundance should be spent this way rather than another. The premise is now stated first and the abundance demoted to its enabling condition: **a name spoken aloud is an address, an address requires someone other than yourself, and the sport exists to distribute that address equally**. §1 is rewritten around it, opening on Carnegie's maxim and inverting it (offered as a technique for advantage; kept here for the recognition, with the advantage engineered out, since nobody chooses whose name is said), with the own-name attention literature supplying the narrower empirical leg that §11 is careful to distinguish from the broader claim. Every mechanism in §§3–8 is unchanged; several are now *derived* rather than asserted — equal-yet-random, the impartial caller, the absence of per-participant statistics, and the

dyadic point all follow from the premise in four lines. **New §5.3 states the constraint the premise forces and the prior specification violated: no participant may be called in their own voice.** A system holding participant-recorded name audio for pronunciation will reach for it at call time and deliver each player a recording of themselves — not a poor address but *no address at all*. §5.3 separates the two speech acts a single artifact had been performing (the pronunciation, which belongs to the name's owner; the call, which necessarily does not) and specifies the transfer between them; **Call accordingly speaks every name in one uniform voice**, which is claimed as a property rather than conceded as a limitation, since a uniform channel addresses all participants identically. Claims grow from nineteen to **twenty-one; the prior-art clock for claims 20–21 runs from this push**. P-S6 pre-registers the premise itself with two named counter-hypotheses (habituation; celebration), publish-either-way. Two honest limits are added and are the paper's most exposed: the address premise is *asserted, not measured*, and the uniform synthetic voice satisfies the constraint's letter — it is an other — while only partly satisfying its spirit, since it is not a person who spent attention on you. That gap is handled by ranking the formats (**Relay remains the default; Call is the device-plentiful case**) rather than by pretending it closes. §5.3 also specifies the gap's partial repair, added at founder request in the same pass and **claimed as claim 22: the cross-recording chain**, in which each participant records one *other* participant's name — the circle called in its own voices, with the naive form of that idea (playing each participant their own recording) barred by the constraint and the intuition preserved by inverting the implementation. Two persona references are corrected as stale in the same pass: the call is the bare name, carrying no speaker-attribution prefix — which the address premise independently requires, since a prefix names a speaker who does not exist — and the rabbit mascot no longer teaches this sport. The title changed with the spine, from *An Impartially-Called Circulation Sport for the AI Age* to *A Circulation Sport in Which Everyone Is Called by Another*; the v4 note above records the title as it then stood.

v6 note (2026-07-30): **one correction the paper owed itself, one new mechanism, and the accumulated backlog folded in.** The correction first, stated rather than tightened quietly: §4 and claim 3 gave the equal-distribution guarantee **over a session**, and a session is a *prefix* of a round — so the published wording **overstated what the mechanism delivers**, and §2's classroom scene described precisely the case that fails. Both now read **over a complete round**. The reference-implementation defect that surfaced this — a caller whose progress reset each session, so that a class of thirty running a ten-minute warm-up called the same ten children every day and never called the other twenty — is specified as new **§4.3 and claim 23, round continuity via circle-scoped progress persistence**: the mechanism that makes claim 3 reachable under real usage, and one whose absence **no session-level test detects**, since within any one session the distribution is exactly correct. **The prior-art clock for claim 23, and for amended claim 3, runs from this push.** Also corrected: **the player minimums**, written before the relay format and silently assuming the caller was not a person. The abstract and §3 said *one to N players* and §3.1 gave per-mode minimums as low as one — while a human relay caller is a person who is not receiving, which makes a circle of one impossible in the very format this paper names as its default. The floor is **four**, now stated once in §3 with its reason, and the per-mode minimums are **withdrawn rather than restated**, so that one number cannot drift out of step with another. New material, none of it changing an existing claim: **§6 gains the two difficulty dials** — the

circle's radius, and method restriction read upward — with the *declare what, never why* guard, whose sharpest risk is accessibility rather than fairness (a legible difficulty badge invites a circle to read a body as a declaration); these had shipped to the CC0 rules and never reached the specification, a drift running product→paper rather than the usual direction. **§5 states what the two arrows actually do** — they relocate the opponent, from a person, to the drop, to the circle's own earlier state. And **§9.1 adds P-S7 and P-S8**, which test the premise *beneath* the mission rather than the sport, and which can be run without the sport at all: if P-S7 fails, this sport may pass every other prediction here and still be a well-made game with no mission. Claims grow from twenty-two to **twenty-three**; pre-registrations from six to **eight**. **Added in the same pass, after a literature check the previous draft of P-S7 had gestured at without performing**: §10 now surveys **the name-and-belonging literature** and states plainly which side of the relation it sits on — Cooper et al. (2017) on *perceived* instructor knowing, Kohli and Solórzano (2012) on mispronunciation as racial microaggression, Walton and Cohen (2011) as the outcome-side evidence that belonging moves at all, and Goodenow (1993) as the instrument P-S7 and P-S8 specify rather than invent. **All of it runs teacher → student**, and the authors are aware of no controlled study of *student-to-student full-coverage* name knowledge — which is P-S7's actual subject, stated as a gap rather than a discovery. §13 also gains a **flourish, explicitly marked as one**: the Khmer ស្តី sounds like the English *say*, the two are unrelated, and the paragraph carries its own deletion test.

v7 note (2026-08-13): a **floor correction, and the rare one where the shipped product was ahead of the paper**. The implementation has been running Call at three players while this document said four globally. §3's *Why four is the floor* is replaced by *Why the floor moves with the format*: the surprise condition (three receivers) is restated **once** as an invariant, and the only variable — whether a body is spent on calling — supplies **Relay 4, Call 3**. No claim is added; a variable that was always implicit in the derivation is made explicit. This does **not** reinstate the per-mode minimum table withdrawn in v6, and it does **not** close the open Team-format question, which is named in §3 rather than left to silence.

v8 note (2026-09-23): **the caller contract now has two versions, and the first one had a measured defect this paper did not know about**. The published caller (v1) kept a player from being called twice in a row across a round boundary by *rotating* the colliding opener to the end of the new round — and that rotation made a round's closer close the next round with probability $2/n$, **two times in three at Call's floor of three**, which is the equal-yet-random promise's *unpredictable* half failing exactly where the circle is smallest. Circles created from 13 September 2026 deal a second version (v2: a 64-hex-character seed, a keyed draw per round, and a boundary *swap* in place of the rotation); every older circle replays v1 byte for byte, forever, because **the seed's type is the version**. New **§4.4** states the finding, the repair and the versioning rule, with the reference implementation's own measurement (v1 66.7% → v2 49.5% at three players). §4's *anyone's name may be next* is **scoped rather than withdrawn**: it is true of the circle and not of every call, since a bag forces each round's last name for anyone counting and the no-repeat rule keeps the previous closer from opening. §11 gains two honest limits (the v1 defect persists in every circle created before the change; the unpredictability is watcher-level, and a locally generated seed is recomputable but never independent of whoever generated it). §10 now says plainly that the recomputable shuffle beneath the caller is **not new** and points to *Decided by No One*, the companion paper that generalises the draw and carries its census. **No claim is added, withdrawn or reworded**; claim 17 reads over both versions of the contract. The body's retired hash-

footer sentence is removed under the 2026-08-27 ruling, since that hash is recorded outside the file it would describe.

v9 note (2026-09-26): **a repair pass for an examiner-facing mirror; no claim is added or withdrawn.** Claim 3(b) and the abstract's *anyone's name may be next* are scoped to the limits §4.4 already states. The sport is named **sey**, lowercase and unmarked, wherever the sport is meant; **B-SeySM** (the app) and **B-SeyTM** (the ball) name only the products, which is the naming the institution adopted after first publication. Unscoped priority and novelty wording is removed or bounded by the censuses now reported in the Prior-Art statement and §10, which also gains the nearest name-game and name-pronunciation prior art. Three **Current form** notes state where the design as now specified has moved past the text (§3 embodied machines; §7 the mesh and the voiced ball; §9.2 sponsorship), the earlier text being retained as a disclosed variant. A **Terms** table maps coined names to standard terms, and these notes now stand in date order. Corrected outright: §11's *unbuilt and unplayed* (a reference implementation exists), §11's placement of the mesh on the first session's critical path (Relay removed it), the dating of golf handicapping, and three citations (the director of *Mystic Ball*, the full title of Brandt's study, and the title of the companion paper cited as *Need-Compiled Questlines*, which is *The Quest That Mints Nothing*).

Abstract

This paper discloses a group ball game in which an automated caller announces, before each strike, the name of the player who must receive next, choosing receivers by a seeded, recomputable shuffle that gives every player the same number of receptions per round in an order participants cannot anticipate, and applies handicaps only as unequal starting scores. The design premise follows. A name spoken aloud is not a sound but an **address**, and an address requires someone other than yourself. Carnegie's maxim — that a person's name is the sweetest sound in any language — reads as a fact about acoustics and is really a fact about *attention*: what a remembered name proves is that another person spent some on you and kept it. This paper takes that as a design premise and asks what a game would be if it guaranteed the sweetest sound to every participant equally, removed the choice of whom to address from human hands entirely, and refused to let the address become a rating. The derivation is tight: **everyone addressed** (equal-yet-random distribution), **nobody choosing** (an impartial caller), **no evaluation** (no per-participant statistics anywhere in the system), **the address completed** (a dyadic scoring unit credited to no individual), and — the consequence a naive implementation gets wrong — **no participant ever called in their own voice**, because a recording of yourself saying your own name is not an address but a mirror.

The guarantee was unbuildable until recently, which is the second half of the problem. Sport has historically been designed under three scarcities. **Umpires are scarce**, so games tolerate bad calls, and the figure of the referee absorbs abuse severe enough to drive large numbers of officials out of school and youth sport in several countries. **Fair opponents are scarce**, so sport is organized as segregation infrastructure — by age, sex, size, and skill — and the one social unit that most needs shared play, the mixed-age family, is the unit organized sport serves worst (§1 names golf's handicap as the partial exception). **Witness is scarce**, so games keep score of *persons*, and the counting hardens into statistics, rankings, and fame hierarchies — the

attention economy's atom, present at the playground. Machine intelligence can lift all three scarcities at once. A sport *designed for* that abundance — rather than an old sport with cameras added — can spend it on what the scarcities stole: inclusion, giving, and story. The order of the two halves is load-bearing and easy to invert: **the address is the premise and the lifted scarcities are the enabling condition**. An impartial announcer is worth building only if there is a reason every person present should be named aloud.

This paper specifies such a sport. **sey** — named for its ancestor, the Southeast Asian *sey* (Khmer ស៊ី, the dusk game of collective keep-alive), and implemented commercially as the B-SeySM app — is a circle game played by **four or more in Relay and three or more in Call** with foot or paddle, with or without a net, cooperatively or adversarially, and organized by one mechanism: **the caller**. A machine intermediary announces, before each strike, the *name* of the player who must receive next — distributing touches **equally yet randomly**, so that participation is egalitarian, attention is universal (anyone's name may be next, within the structural limits §4.4 states), and, as a structural by-product, *strangers learn each other's names through play*. That selection is not a judgement but an **arithmetic**: the receiver sequence is a pure function of the roster and a seed declared before play, so any participant may recompute a finished session and confirm that nobody was skipped and nobody was protected. The sport's central fairness property is therefore *audited rather than trusted* — which is why this specification describes the caller as **impartial** rather than as artificial intelligence, a distinction §4.2 makes structural. Because the caller designates receivers on both sides of the net, targeting a weaker opponent is not merely discouraged but **absent from the game's move-set**: exploiting the weakest human present is structurally impossible. The point is **dyadic** — it increments on successful *receipt*, so every score is a completed give-and-receive and no one scores alone. Handicaps are applied **at the start line, never in the stream**: unequal teams begin at unequal countdown numbers on a coarse fixed lattice (multiples of three), a quantization that makes the handicap read as a garment size rather than a skill rating. Cooperative play counts *up* (the collective streak); adversarial play counts *down* to zero — first to nothing wins. The announcement reaches the circle in one of three named formats, of which the default — **the relay call** — speaks the name *privately to a single rotating human*, who calls it aloud: fairness stays machine-held while delivery is human, so the sport runs on **one borrowed device** with no loudspeaker, no network, and no clock synchronization, and the rotating relay is where participants practise *producing* the names they otherwise only hear. Where devices are plentiful, a **synced-device mesh** speaks the call in unison instead, in **one voice for every name** — never the named player's own recording — so that every participant is addressed identically, which is the equal-yet-random property rendered in the acoustic domain as well as the numeric one. Pronunciation authority nonetheless stays with the name's owner in both formats, transferred to a foreign articulator either by modeled repetition (the relay hears the owner's recording immediately before speaking) or by an owner-supplied **respelling** that drives the uniform voice — the pronunciation and the call being two distinct speech acts whose rightful speakers differ.

The sport is parameterized on three orthogonal axes — **method** (the body vocabulary each player declares: hand, paddle, or foot, mixed freely within one circle), **mode** (what the circle plays against: nothing, its own record, or another circle), and **level** (the *lead time* between the call and the object's arrival). The default state has **no score at all**, and its stated purpose is that everyone learns everyone's name with correct pronunciation; at the longest lead time the called player raises a hand, so the ladder from easy to hard is a **scaffold-fading memory curve** rather than a skill ladder — the game becomes more difficult exactly as the group's name recall improves. Scoring degrades gracefully across three tiers — **implied by the call**,

validated by a k-of-N vote of the circle's own microphones, or confirmed by an accelerometer in the object — none of which gates play, and all of which are licensed to be loose because the score moves no value. The system is **local-first**: the entire game runs on one device, offline, with no accounts. **Twenty-three claims** are enumerated and dedicated to the public domain; **eight predictions** are pre-registered, including the design's own existential wager and a test of the address premise itself, both of which the authors commit to publishing either way.

Keywords: designed sport, automated turn assignment, receiver selection, seeded shuffle, publicly verifiable random selection, handicap by starting score, AI officiating, AI-called circulation sport, AI-directed pass calling, deterministic turn assignment, circle game, sey, chinlone, sepak takraw, mixed-age play, handicap systems, loneliness intervention, third place, name learning, cooperative games, defensive publication.

Prior-Art and Non-Assertion Statement

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The following terms are coined in this paper and simultaneously freed with it: **AI-called circulation sport**, **the caller mechanism**, **equal-yet-random distribution**, **the cannot-target-weakness property**, **the dyadic scoring unit**, **start-line handicap** and **quantization-for-dignity**, **the last-gift rule**, **the synced-circle mesh**, and **the play/currency wall**. Freed with the v2 revision: **the call-lead-time ladder**, **scaffold-fading difficulty**, **method-as-declared-handicap**, **the implied point**, **circle-scoped adaptation**, **the acoustic inversion**, **rosterless classroom mode**, and **the sponsorable-place test**. Freed with the 2026-07-27 seat pass: **determined and judged seats**, **the seat-migration bar**, **the determined caller**, **count-only circle coherence**, **the host-agnostic turn-assignment layer**, and **the relay call**. Freed with the 2026-07-27 address pass: **the address premise**, **the address constraint**, **the uniform calling voice**, **pronunciation-authority transfer**, and **the cross-recording chain**. Terms inherited from this corpus's earlier publications (Proof of CoordinateSM; the mints-nothing boundary; the beating credential) are cited, not re-claimed.

Smart balls, computer-vision officiating, and AI sports-coaching applications are active prior art and an active patent field (§10); the present claims are confined to the *pre-announced named-receiver*, *equal-random-distribution*, *dual-arrow*, *lattice-handicapped circle-sport architecture* and to its dignity-preserving constraint set, which is the part an extractive implementation would omit.

What the censuses found. Two desk surveys bear on these claims, and both narrowed them. (1) The census reported in the companion paper *Circulation Sports* (22 published warm-up, drill and icebreaker formats across seven sports and the physical-education and icebreaker literature; 2026-08-07; documented practice, not fieldwork) found guaranteed reach common, in four architectures (the queue, fixed role rotation, round completion, and turn-taking norms), and found names already called in a circle: in the soccer *Passing Name Game* the passer calls the name of their own chosen receiver, and in the *Name Toss* icebreaker a round closes when everyone has received once. Not found in that aperture on that date: reach that is guaranteed **and** whose order stays unpredictable across unbounded play, held by a party other than the passer. That conjunction, the external caller, is what claims 1–3 disclose. (2) A survey of name-pronunciation tools

(2026-08-17) found the recording of a name's pronunciation by its owner widely practised (§10); claim 21 discloses its use to transfer pronunciation authority to another speaker, not the recording itself. The recomputable shuffle beneath the caller is established prior art (§10). No census has been run on the cannot-target-weakness property, the start-line lattice, or the dual-arrow ruleset, and nothing here asserts that they are new.

1 • The Premise: A Name, Said by Someone Else

"A person's name is to that person the sweetest and most important sound in any language." — Dale Carnegie, *How to Win Friends and Influence People* (1936)

Carnegie offered that as a **technique**. The advice was instrumental — learn names, gain advantage — and the century of sales training built on it has made the sentence faintly embarrassing to quote. This paper keeps the observation and discards the instrumentality. In the sport specified below **nobody chooses whose name is said**, so no participant can deploy a name to their own benefit; the recognition survives and the advantage is engineered out. What remains is the plain finding underneath the salesmanship, which experimental attention research reached independently and from a different direction: a person's own name penetrates a channel they were not attending to, where other words do not (the own-name effect within the cocktail-party phenomenon).

The premise of this sport is one step past that finding, and it is a step Carnegie did not need to take because he was addressing a speaker rather than designing a system.

A name spoken aloud is not a sound. It is an *address* — and an address requires someone other than yourself.

Your own name in your own voice is not an address at all; it is a recording. Nobody is calling you. The sweetness Carnegie describes is not acoustic — it is the evidence a name carries that *another person spent attention on you and kept it*. A remembered name is a receipt for attention already given. This is why being greeted by name by a shopkeeper lands differently from a personalized mail-merge, and why the difference is not one of technology but of **who is doing the addressing**.

From that single premise the sport's architecture follows almost without further argument:

- **Everyone must be addressed, and often.** A game in which some players are called and others are merely present has distributed the sweetest sound unequally, which is what the playground already does. Hence **equal-yet-random** distribution (§4) — equal so that nobody is under-addressed, random so that the address cannot be anticipated and therefore cannot be dismissed.
- **Nobody may choose whom to address.** The instant a participant selects receivers, the address becomes a favor, and a favor withheld is an exclusion. Hence the caller is an **impartial intermediary** and, at §4.2, not even a judgement: an arithmetic that any participant can recompute.
- **The address must not become an evaluation.** A name said because you are good is a rating; a name said because it is your turn is recognition. Hence **no per-player statistics anywhere in the system** (§4.1, §7.1) — the sport that says your name most also refuses to say how you did.

- **The address must be completed.** An address ignored is worse than none. Hence the **dyadic point** (§5): the scoring unit is a call *received*, credited to nobody alone, so the sport's atom is a completed exchange between two people rather than an achievement by one.
- **And no participant may be called in their own voice** (§5.2). This is the premise's hardest and most easily violated consequence, and the one a naive implementation gets wrong: a system holding a recording of each player's name will reach for it at call time, and deliver to each player a recording of themselves. That is not a sport that says your name. It is a mirror.

What the sport produces, then, is not fitness and not a winner. It is a quantity of **addressed attention**, distributed evenly by construction, in a setting where the people doing the addressing are strangers who will now be able to greet each other.

Why no sport has done this

The premise is not new — every coach who learns thirty names by the second practice is acting on it. What is new is the possibility of *guaranteeing* it, and the guarantee was, until recently, unbuildable. Sport is one of humanity's great social technologies, and like every technology it embodies the constraints of its era. Three of those constraints did most of the shaping, and all three stand between the premise above and any game that could deliver it.

The officiating constraint. A fair game needs a neutral judge, and neutral judges are expensive. Most human play therefore proceeds unofficiated — with the familiar result that disputes end games, dominant personalities adjudicate in their own favor, and children learn early that the loudest voice owns the rules. Where officiating exists, it concentrates in a single fallible human who becomes the game's lightning rod: abuse of referees is severe enough that officiating bodies in the United States and the United Kingdom have reported large losses of officials, attributed largely to the behaviour of adults, with games cancelled or moved for want of officials. The referee crisis is not a culture problem that better manners will fix; it is a *structure* problem — one human absorbing the full adversarial pressure of everyone else's stakes.

The matching constraint. A good game needs opponents of comparable ability, and comparable opponents are rare. Sport's solution was segregation: leagues by age, divisions by skill, categories by sex and weight. The solution works — and quietly forecloses the most valuable game that could exist: the one where a grandmother, a teenager, and a six-year-old contest the same point and all three matter. The family, the one social unit whose play would repair the most, is the unit sport's architecture serves worst. (The lone mainstream counterexample, golf's handicap system, proves the demand: it is the reason golf is one of very few sports a parent and child can genuinely contest, and it required a century of institutional machinery to maintain.)

The witness constraint. A game's story needs recording, and recording was expensive, so sport recorded the cheapest summary: *who scored*. From that compression grew the entire statistical culture of sport — batting averages, rankings, ladders, most-valuable-player awards — a fame hierarchy erected on a bookkeeping shortcut. The consequences run downhill to the playground: the child picked last exists because informal sport, too, keeps score of persons; the pickup game has a status economy, and everyone present knows their rank in it.

Machine intelligence can lift all three scarcities. Officiating becomes abundant (a phone judges a line call better than a linesman); matching becomes computable (fairness can be *manufactured* rather than found); witness becomes total (everything can be recorded, which forces the question of what *should* be). The default path — already visibly underway in the patent literature (§10) — is to spend this abundance on the old game: more statistics, finer player-surveillance, engagement-optimized training loops. The sport specified below spends it in the opposite direction: on inclusion the matching constraint forbade, on giving the scoring compression erased, and on an output sport has rarely set out to produce — *strangers who know each other's names*.

The relation between this section's two halves should be stated exactly, because it is easy to invert. **The address is the premise; the lifted scarcities are the enabling condition.** The abundance did not suggest the goal — a tireless impartial announcer is worth building only if there is a reason every person present should be named aloud, and Carnegie's observation is that reason. What the abundance supplies is the *guarantee*: a circle can now promise every participant an equal share of being addressed, and keep the promise for the whole session, without asking a human to hold the ledger. Everything downstream — the seats, the arithmetic, the two count-arrows, the start-line lattice — exists to protect that guarantee from the ordinary social forces that erode it. A useful test of any proposed change to this specification is therefore not *does it make the game better* but **does it keep everyone being called by another**.

A design axiom governs throughout, shared by all three papers of this sprint and coined here as **the play/currency wall**: *competition and play may generate the story; only witnessed giving moves the currency*. Winning, in any game this institution builds, may move narrative, honor, or the address of an already-committed gift — never value itself. The wall's application to stakes and patronage is its own paper (*The Wager That Isn't*, this sprint); its application here is simpler and prior: in *sey*, there is nothing to move. What victory produces is a story.

2 • The Canonical Scenes

A park, late afternoon. A man finishes a quiet quarter-hour on a bench — the contemplative practice is its own product and no part of this paper — and walks toward a loose ring of people batting a rattan-weight ball into the air. He does not know any of them. Someone widens the circle; he types a name into the app — just *Virak* — and his phone joins the mesh. A moment later every phone in the circle says, in one voice, one word: "*Virak!*" The ball comes to him — gently; the woman who sent it saw a newcomer, and delivery is the whole skill of this game. He gets his paddle under it. The circle cheers the streak alive. Within three rounds, everyone in the circle has heard his name four times, and he has heard all of theirs, because the game cannot proceed without saying them. When the streak dies at 41 — nine short of nothing in particular, since the next rite waits at 333 — the circle groans and laughs, and a stranger says, "Again, Virak?" That sentence — a stranger using his name to invite him back — is the sport's actual product. The rally was the packaging.

A living room, that evening. Three generations, one net strung between two chairs. The eight-year-old and her grandmother hold paddles; the parents play with their feet. The family's phones announce in two languages — the grandmother's in Khmer, the child's in English — one circle, one game, two tongues. The teams are uneven, so the app has set the start numbers: the parents begin at 33, the paddle side at 21. First

to zero. Nobody chose those numbers; nobody can argue with them; and because the caller decides who receives, the parents cannot serve at the eight-year-old to win — the game has no such move. When the paddle side takes its last point — actively won, as the final point must be — the child performs a victory lap of the sofa. What she has won is the story of having beaten her parents fairly. That is all winning moves here, and it is enough; it has always been enough.

A classroom, the first week of school. Thirty children who mostly do not know each other, one teacher who needs to learn thirty names, one ball. The circle solves both problems, because equal-yet-random guarantees every child is called **once the round completes** — and because the round is carried across sessions rather than restarted (§4.3), a class playing ten minutes a day reaches every child instead of cycling the same few. The teacher, standing inside the circle, hears every name spoken aloud dozens of times. No child is picked last, because there is no picking. No child dominates, because the caller will not allow the ball to orbit the confident. The physical-education period and the social-integration project turn out to be the same forty minutes.

3 · The Design: One Circle, Five Seats

The sport is a circle game for **four or more players in Relay and three or more in Call** (the floor is a function of the format axis; see *Why the floor moves with the format* below), played with a ball designed to be struck by **foot or paddle** — the athletic adult kicks, the grandparent and the child paddle, and both choices are ordinary equipment decisions, not accommodations. Play proceeds in two modes. **Without a net**, the circle plays cooperative keep-alive: the score counts *up*, one per completed reception, and the object is the longest unbroken streak — the collective form. **With a net**, two sides contest a countdown (§5–6) under volleyball-like rally structure — the adversarial form, and the form on which the companion paper's challenge grammar (B-MatchSM) nests. A newcomer joins either form the same way: the circle widens. There are no teams to pick in circle mode and no tryout in either; the topology itself is the invitation. **Why the floor moves with the format.** The floor is not a constant but a **function of one variable — whether the caller is a person**. The derivation is single and does not change: **three receivers are required**, because three is the smallest number that leaves any surprise in the call. With two receivers the caller can only alternate — everyone knows who is next before the name is said, and the mechanism this paper specifies contributes nothing.

What changes is only whether a body is spent on calling. **In Relay a human calls and is therefore not receiving, so three receivers cost four players. In Call no human calls, so all present are receivers, and three receivers cost three.** One rule, applied to two arrangements:

required receivers = 3		(invariant – the surprise condition)
Relay	caller is a person	→ floor = 3 + 1 = 4
Call	caller is not	→ floor = 3 + 0 = 3

This is deliberately *not* a return to the per-mode minimum table withdrawn in v6. That table restated a number per row, which is exactly how two numbers drift apart. This states the number **once**, as the surprise

condition, and lets the format axis supply the only term that varies. The withdrawal stands; what is added is the variable it was missing.

Provenance, stated asymmetrically because it is asymmetric. The invariant and its derivation are this paper's own, unchanged since v1. **Three-in-Call is not** — it is prior canon in the product's own design record, where a circle of three standing close with no human caller was specified as the answer for a family of three, and it is the implementation that has been running while this paper said otherwise. The adjacent argument that three is the smallest number at which forward and back differ belongs to the circulation-sport work and is **cited here, not claimed**.

A gap this amendment does not close, and should not be read as closing. The paper still says nothing about **which formats a Team game may run**, whether a relay caller belongs to a side, or how rotation crosses a net. The floor above is stated for Relay and Call only. Team ships visibly disabled for exactly this reason, and until the axis is specified the honest position is that the format question is open rather than answered by omission.

The machine intelligence in the sport occupies exactly **four seats** — including the one the sport is named for — and is barred from the fifth. The seats fall into two classes, and the division is not a taxonomy for its own sake: it decides how each seat's output can be *checked*, and therefore what an implementer is permitted to put in it.

The determined seats. Their output is a pure function of inputs declared before play, so it is checkable by **recomputation** — anyone holding the inputs reproduces the result exactly and sees for themselves that the rule was honoured.

1. **Caller.** The sport's defining mechanism (§4): before each play, the name of the required next receiver, announced aloud. Its selection policy is equal-yet-random and, given the circle and a declared seed, *deterministic* (§4.2) — an arithmetic distribution, not a live opinion about anybody.
2. **Equalizer.** Fairness is manufactured at two points and only two: the **start line** (asymmetric countdown numbers, §6) and the **implement** (paddle or foot, chosen by the player), both drawn from a coarse published lattice. It is never manufactured mid-play. The distinction is load-bearing and stated as a hard rule below.

The judged seats. Their output is a perception or a narration. It cannot be reproduced from inputs, so it is checkable only by **explanation** — each judgment stating its ground in one sentence, the standard §5 already imposes on the last-gift ruling.

3. **Umpire.** Line calls, receipt validity, and the classification of the final point (§5) are the system's judgments — instant, neutral, and not attached to a human being who can be shouted at. The referee crisis is answered not by braver referees but by removing the seat the abuse was aimed at.
4. **Witness.** The system records the game's story — the streak, the rally, the celebration — as a *collective* chronicle. It records no player statistics: no individual completion rates, no rankings, no most-valuable anything (§7–8). What it counts, it counts about the circle.

The barred seat.

5. **Player — never.** No machine plays. In an age when most activities can be delegated to software, the sport is constructed entirely from the one thing that cannot be: bodies, co-present, attending to each other. The machine is present so that the humans can be.

Current form. The design as now specified admits an embodied machine into play on one condition: that it displaces no human — not a receiver, not the caller, not an opposing team. Where that holds, a machine may receive (for example as a third receiver when only two people are present, which restores the surprise condition of §3), or may stand as the opposing side in net mode; it keeps the object moving but never keeps the score, since a pass involving a machine counts toward no streak or record; it may never take the relay role, which exists so that people practise saying names; and it plays at a deliberately human level and is never preferred to a person. In Call it may also serve as the single speaker in place of the device mesh. The machine-free rule above is retained as a disclosed variant.

The seat-migration bar. A seat may not take on the other class's mode of operation, and the prohibition runs in both directions because both failures arrive at the same place — a machine-held ranking of persons. A *determined* seat that acquires judgment becomes a rating engine: a caller that routes around a struggling receiver, or a handicapper that tunes start numbers to measured ability, has evaluated the players, and has done it where no one can see it. A *judged* seat that acquires distribution authority becomes a caller: an umpire empowered to influence who receives next can express a preference about people through a channel built for judgments about the ball. The rule is short enough to hold in mind while implementing: **the determined seats never judge a person; the judged seats never choose a person.**

3.1 · The three axes: method, mode, level

The sport is parameterized on three orthogonal axes. They are not settings; they are a **ladder**, and an implementation that surfaces them as a configuration screen has already failed the design.

AXIS	QUESTION IT ANSWERS	VALUES
METHOD	what part of you gives?	hand · paddle · foot
MODE	what do you play against?	nothing · your record · another circle
LEVEL	how much warning?	long lead · moderate · short lead

Method is the body vocabulary a player declares — hand-catch-and-release, paddle, or foot. Anatomy plus implement exhausts the list; there is no fourth. The values are **defaults suggested by ability, never assignments by category**, and heterogeneous methods are expected *within a single circle*: a grandparent with a paddle, a child with hands, an adult with feet, one shared object. This is the load-bearing case, not the exotic one — a sport that segregates by method has thrown away the mixed-age property that is the design's principal social claim, and would have reintroduced by the back door the segregation §1 identifies as sport's inherited disease.

A declared method **is a start-line handicap** (§6) — public, self-chosen, announced before play, never assigned during it — so the axis requires no new fairness machinery; it inherits the machinery already specified. Two consequences follow:

- **The object is constrained by the axis.** One shared object must be catchable, kickable, and paddle-able. A hard ball fails hands; a shuttlecock fails paddle power. A **soft weighted sack** satisfies all three, which is

why the reference implementation is a sack rather than a ball.

- **A catch stops flight, so possession needs a bound.** Hand players receive by catching, which would otherwise let a player hold the object and stall the circle. The rule: **catch and release within one beat, where the caller's own cadence is the release clock.** As lead time shortens (§4.1) the hand method converts from catch-and-throw to volley-tap without a rule change — difficulty emerges from the method mixture rather than being imposed on it.

Mode is what the circle plays against, and the values ascend: *nothing* (**Friendship**, no scoring of any kind), *its own record* (**Streak**, no net, ascending collective count), *another circle* (**Team**, net, descending count to zero, and the only mode additionally requiring enough players to form two sides). All three take their floor from the single rule of §3 — **three receivers, plus a body for the caller only where the caller is a person** (Relay 4, Call 3). The per-mode minimum *table* given in revisions before v6 remains withdrawn and is not restored: it restated a number per row, which is how two numbers drift apart. One number, stated once, with one variable. The mode names are deliberate: **no label on the product surface names rivalry**, though the adversarial mode is genuinely adversarial and this paper describes it as such. Naming the third mode for its structural fact — *sides exist* — rather than for its disposition is a small instance of a general discipline in this corpus, in which vocabulary is held to the same standard as mechanism.

The mode ladder is also the **adoption funnel**, and an unusually honest one: each rung is entered by the circle's own election, each rung's graduation is the previous rung's success condition, and the entry rung has **no score at all**.

Level is treated in §4.1, because it is a property of the caller rather than of the players.

The three-value pattern is not aesthetic and should not be read as one. Each axis has an independent reason for its cardinality: method is exhausted by anatomy plus implement; mode is exhausted by the opponent relation; level is coarsely quantized for the same anti-rating reason the start-line lattice is (§6) — a continuously variable difficulty dial would read as a precision skill rating, which is the artifact this design exists to avoid. Where a fourth value would genuinely serve — very large circles may want a fourth lead-time band — the pattern must yield. **Three is a finding here, not a constraint.**

4 · The Caller: Equal-Yet-Random, and the Property It Buys

The sport's central mechanism is small enough to state in a sentence: **before each strike, the system announces by name the player who must receive next.**

Everything distinctive about the sport follows from that sentence.

Equal-yet-random distribution. The caller's selection policy has two commitments that are individually common and, held jointly by a party other than the passer, were not found in the census reported in the Prior-Art statement. *Equal*: **over a complete round** — one pass through the roster — every player in the circle receives the same number of touches, within rounding, and the weakest player is guaranteed the strongest player's share of the game. **Revisions of this paper before v6 stated this over a session, and that overstated it**: a session is a prefix of a round, and a prefix of a fair sequence is not fair. The guarantee

is reachable under real usage only because rounds are carried across sessions rather than restarted (§4.3). *Random*: the order is unpredictable, so no player can disengage — anyone's name may be next, and the suspense that in ordinary sport attaches only to the ball here attaches to every person simultaneously. *Anyone's name may be next* is true of the circle rather than of every call, and §4.4 states the exact scope: within a round the bag forces the last name for anyone who counts, the no-repeat rule keeps the previous closer from opening the next round, and the first published version of the caller leaked more predictability than either — a round's closer closed the next one two times in three at the smallest circle. Equality without randomness would be a queue (predictable, boring, and stigmatizing — everyone can see whose turn is being "given"); randomness without equality is every pickup game ever played (the ball orbits the skilled). The conjunction is the mechanism.

The cannot-target-weakness property. In net mode, the caller designates receivers on *both* sides. The attacking side therefore cannot choose to serve at the weakest opponent — the oldest strategy in net sports, taught openly at every level, and the precise mechanism by which the weakest player on any volleyball court spends the match being hunted. In sey that strategy does not exist. It is not penalized; it is not discouraged; it is *absent from the move-set*, the way castling into check is absent from chess. Skill, denied the target-selection channel, migrates entirely into **delivery** — placing the ball so your designated receiver, whoever the caller named, can continue the play. The best player in a sey circle is definitionally the one who makes everyone else look good, because making the named receiver succeed is the only thing the rules allow skill to do. It is disclosed here as the design's sharpest single contribution (Claim 2); no census of net sports has been run for it.

The name as by-product and as point. Because the call is a *name*, spoken aloud, repeatedly, by every device in the circle (§7), the sport performs introductions as a side effect of its basic loop. This is not a social feature bolted onto a game; it is the game's addressing layer, doing double duty. The design intends the double duty (§9's first prediction measures it): the sport is built so that its standard output includes *strangers who know each other's names* — the missing primitive of the third place. Name games such as the *Name Toss* icebreaker pursue the same output without a caller (§10); what the caller adds is that no participant chooses whose name is said.

Hard constraints on the caller (stated here as design law; their governance form lives in the institution's internal directive registry):

- The caller **never evaluates players in the flow of play**. It does not skew calls by skill, win probability, or match situation; it does not route around a struggling receiver at a tense moment. A caller that "protects" the weak player at match point has rebuilt picked-last-at-recess inside an algorithm, invisibly, which is worse than the playground original because it cannot be seen and argued with. Fairness lives at the start line only.
- The caller speaks **chosen names only** — the name a player registers for the circle, which may be a nickname; children's circles use first names or nicknames as a rule. No legal name is ever broadcast across a public park.
- Per-player data that the equalizer uses (implement choice, start-number calibration) is a **private mirror** — visible to the player, never to the circle, never to any ranking, never retained as a skill profile.

4.1 • Level as call lead time: a scaffold-fading memory curve

The naive difficulty dial for a called sport is the interval between calls. It is the wrong variable: the inter-call interval is confounded by circle size, so the same setting produces a frantic game with four players and a languid one with thirty. The correct variable is **call lead time** — the interval between the naming of the receiver and the object's arrival. Lead time is invariant to circle size and to method, and it is what a receiver actually experiences as pressure.

Three bands are specified, and what changes across them is not merely speed but **how much external scaffolding supports the act of recognition**:

LEVEL	LEAD TIME	SCAFFOLD	WHAT IS BEING TRAINED
Easy	long	called player RAISES A HAND and may speak their own name aloud	nothing yet – the circle is being taught the names
Medium	moderate	none – the giver must find the named face unaided	name → face recall
Hard	short	none; the call may land while the object is aloft	automaticity under time pressure

At the longest lead the called player **raises a hand**, which removes the recall requirement entirely: a giver who does not yet know who *Sokha* is can simply deliver to the raised hand. The scaffold is then withdrawn — first the hand, then the time — and the withdrawal is enforced by physics rather than by rule, since a hand cannot usefully be raised inside a short lead.

The result is that **the difficulty ladder is a memory curve, not a skill curve**. A circle can only ascend it as its members' name recall becomes fast and then automatic, which yields the design's cleanest coincidence: *the game becomes more fun exactly as everyone learns each other's names*. The thing the players want and the thing the sport is for are the same thing, and no exhortation is required to align them.

It also supplies the sport's non-numeric progression. In Friendship mode there is no score, and the circle nonetheless has something that advances: **tempo is the score that is not a score**.

A constraint the implementer must not violate. It is tempting to advance the level automatically from measured response latency. Doing so *per player* would reconstruct, invisibly and in the tempo dimension, precisely the artifact §4 exists to prevent — a machine-maintained ranking of who is slow. The rule:

▮ **The level is a property of the circle, never of a player.**

Permitted implementations, in order of preference: (a) **the circle elects the level**, with the caller permitted to *offer* an advance; (b) if adaptive at all, adaptation conditions **only on circle-aggregate state**, ephemeral and on-device, never per-player, never stored, never displayed. Never permitted: a per-player recall score, in any form, visible or not.

4.2 • The determined caller: fairness as arithmetic

The caller is the seat where an implementer will most want to put intelligence, and the seat where intelligence does the most damage. This design resolves the tension by removing the caller from the domain of judgment altogether: **the call sequence is a deterministic pure function of the circle's roster and a**

seed declared before play. Given the same roster and seed, every conforming implementation emits a bit-identical sequence, which makes the generator a cross-platform contract rather than an internal detail.

Three properties follow. The third was not anticipated when the constraint was adopted, and is now the reason to keep it.

Fairness becomes verifiable rather than trusted. Equal-yet-random (§4) is the sport's central promise and the one a participant is least able to check by watching, since over any short window a fair sequence and a biased one look alike — which is precisely why a sport that merely *asserts* fair distribution asks to be taken at its word. When the roster and seed are the entire input, any participant, parent, teacher, or competitor can recompute a completed session and confirm that the distribution was equal and that no one was skipped, favoured, or quietly protected. Publishing the generator is therefore part of the mechanism rather than a disclosure concession.

Multi-device play stops requiring a network. Because each device computes the sequence independently, devices in one circle need never be told *who* is next — only **how many calls have elapsed**. A single integer, not a name, is the whole synchronization payload; a device rejoining after a lapse fast-forwards to the current index instead of recovering state. Where simultaneous announcement (§7) demands tight clock alignment, sequence *agreement* demands none at all. The offline-first commitment of §7.1 is thus not merely compatible with the determined caller — it is largely delivered by it.

There is no per-player state to leak, subpoena, or repurpose. The forbidden artifact of §4 and §4.1 — a machine-maintained record of who is slow, who is skipped, who is protected — is not merely prohibited here by policy. A pure function of a roster and a seed has nowhere to keep such a record. The guarantee moves out of the governance layer and into the arithmetic, where a later release cannot quietly relax it and an acquirer cannot monetize it.

The general lesson, offered to implementers of any called game. A fairness property enforced by a rule *about* the algorithm lasts exactly as long as the organization enforcing it; the same property enforced by determinism and published vectors outlasts the organization. Where a guarantee can be made checkable, making it checkable is worth more than making the underlying decision cleverer — and the two are usually opposed, because the intelligence that would improve a decision is the same thing that makes it unauditable. The corollary an implementer meets later is that a checkable sequence can never be *fixed* in place: once a seed has dealt a session somebody may recompute, its sequence is a record. §4.4 is the worked case — a real defect, repaired by versioning the seed rather than the algorithm.

None of this disarms the machine; it relocates it. Perception and narration — was the ball in, was the final point actively won, what is this circle's story — are irreducibly judgments, and they are where sensing and inference legitimately belong. The boundary is worth restating at the hardware layer beside the warning already given there (§7.1): **instrumentation serves the judged seats only**. An accelerometer reporting a touch supplies the umpire with evidence. It must never supply the caller with a reason.

4.3 · Round continuity: the unit is the round, not the session

The equal-distribution guarantee holds over a **complete round** — one pass through the roster — and not over an arbitrary slice of one. The distinction is not pedantry. It is the difference between a working

guarantee and a broken one, and the reference implementation shipped the broken version first.

A class of thirty playing a ten-minute warm-up calls perhaps ten children. If the caller's progress resets when the session ends, the next session calls the same ten, and the twenty children at the far end of the round are never called at all — every day, indefinitely, with nothing on any surface to indicate it. The distribution is perfectly equal within each session and catastrophically unequal across them. **An invariant enforced only within a unit is silently void across units, and the unit boundary is where nobody looks.**

The repair is to persist the round rather than the session. The caller retains a **circle-scoped integer call index** — never a per-participant record, never a timestamp — so that a truncated session resumes where it stopped rather than restarting: whoever has not been called yet is still uncalled tomorrow. This is what makes the guarantee reachable under real usage, in which play is chopped into ten-minute pieces by bells, weather, and attention.

Two properties are worth stating for implementers. First, the persisted state is **a single integer per circle**, which is why it introduces no per-participant artifact and nothing to leak (§4.2). Second, **no amount of session-level testing detects the defect**, because every test anyone would write runs one session, and within one session the distribution is exactly correct. A competitor implementing from this specification would ship the same bug.

4.4 · Two versions of one contract: the closer effect, and the seed as the version

§4.3 recorded a defect that lived at the boundary between sessions and that no session-level test could see. This section records a second defect of the same family — invisible inside any one round, visible only across the boundary between two — and the way it was repaired without altering a single sequence that had already been dealt.

What the first published caller did at a round boundary. Equal-yet-random is dealt as a **bag**: each round is a fresh shuffle of the roster, dealt to its end before the next is drawn, which is what makes the counts equal. Two independent shuffles will sometimes deal the same player last in one round and first in the next — called twice in a row, which the circle hears as a stutter and the player experiences as being singled out. The first version of the cross-platform contract (**v1**: a 32-bit seeded generator, a descending Fisher–Yates shuffle, and the bag, published with conformance vectors in `@333eco/sev`) forbade the repeat with a **rotation**: if a new round would open with the previous round's closer, that player was moved to its end. The rule does what it was written for. Its cost was not measured until 13 September 2026, when a documentation example printed two identical consecutive rounds and the explanation first offered for it was checked rather than accepted. Rotation maps every shuffle that would have opened with the closer onto a shuffle that ends with them, so the previous closer is never first, takes each middle position with probability $1/n$, and **closes the next round with probability $2/n$** — twice the rate of any middle position. A round repeats the previous round's order exactly with probability $2/n!$ rather than $1/n!$.

PLAYERS	v1 ROTATION – closer closes again analytic 2/n	measured *	v2 SWAP – closer closes again analytic 1/(n-1)
3	66.7%	66.8%	50.0% (49.5% †)
4	50.0%	49.9%	33.3%
7	28.6%	28.5%	16.7%
12	16.7%	16.6%	9.1%

* 40,000 seeds per row.

† measured in the reference implementation's own engine, which measured the v1 form at 66.7% under the same conditions.

Why it was this sport's defect before it was anyone else's. The effect is sharpest where the roster is smallest, and the smallest roster this paper permits is Call's floor of three (§3) — a floor derived from the requirement that some surprise remain in the call. At three players a participant who has watched one round could name the *second* call of the next round correctly **two times in three** under v1. Under the repaired form the same guess succeeds one time in two, which is the best any rule forbidding back-to-back calls allows: with the previous closer barred from the opening, the four permitted orders are equally likely. Equal counts were never touched — every round still dealt every player exactly once, and long-run averages remain equal by symmetry — so neither a count nor the recomputation audit of §4.2 could see the defect. It was a failure of *unpredictability*, the half of equal-yet-random that §4 says keeps a player from disengaging, and it was worst at the very floor that exists to protect that half.

The repair. The second version (v2) changes the seed, the generator and the boundary rule, and makes one structural change to Relay. The seed is **32 random bytes written as 64 lowercase hexadecimal characters**. Each round is drawn from its own key — an HMAC-SHA-256 of the seed, a stream label (receivers, or relay callers) and the round number — expanded by an HMAC counter stream and rejection-sampled into uniform indices for the same descending Fisher–Yates shuffle, so there is no 32-bit state. And the boundary rule is a **swap** with a uniformly drawn later position instead of a rotation: the previous closer still never opens the next round, and is equally likely to land anywhere else in it. In Relay, a caller's tenure becomes exactly one receiver round, callers are drawn in rounds of their own over the whole circle, and each receiver round deals everyone except the current caller. The formats, the floors, the level fields, count-only catch-up and the refusal to keep per-player state are unchanged. The normative text is the sport's contract (@333eco/sev 1.1.0, *The caller sequence*, §8), which calls the round key and the keyed shuffle from the general-purpose CC0 package @333eco/primitives (its specification, Parts I–II); both ship vectors, and the contract is sufficient without the package.

Version the seed, never the algorithm. A sequence that anyone may recompute is a record, and the v1 contract had already said what that forbids: changing the sequence for an existing seed is a breaking change, because a circle saved on one device would replay differently on another and every past audit would silently stop reproducing. So v1 was not edited. Circles created from 13 September 2026 carry a v2 seed; every older circle keeps its numeric seed and replays v1 byte for byte, indefinitely. **A client tells the versions apart by the seed's type alone** — a number is v1, a 64-hex string is v2, anything else is not a seed — so no stored circle changed, no version field can be lost or mistyped, and a client must implement both to replay every circle. The contract's earlier format axis was the first instance of the rule, added by making the

absent value mean the old behaviour; v2 is the larger one, and the one that shows why the rule exists. A repair that edited v1 would have fixed the future by falsifying the past.

What *nobody can predict* means, scoped. The property is watcher-level. It says that no one attending to the play can know whose name is next, and it holds within three limits that are structural rather than defects. (a) **The bag forces each round's last name** for anyone who counts, and more generally a player already called in the current round knows they will not be called again before it ends; this is the price of equal counts, and it is paid knowingly, since a draw that could call the same player again at once would give up the equality that is the sport's other half. (b) **The previous closer never opens the next round** — the no-repeat rule's intended and bounded cost. (c) **The sequence is not secret from a device.** Count-only coherence (§4.2) works because every device in the circle holds the seed and computes the same order, so any of them can compute ahead; the unpredictability the sport needs is the absence of a pattern a *player* can read, and v1's closer effect was exactly such a pattern. Beyond these, the seed is generated on the device that opens the circle. Recomputation proves that a session was dealt faithfully from the declared seed; it cannot prove that the opener did not reopen the circle until an order they preferred appeared. For play order that is an acceptable residue. For anything of value it is not, and the companion paper *Decided by No One* specifies the form that removes it — a seed no party controls, a roster committed before the seed can be known — where the draw is generalised beyond this sport.

5 • Scoring: The Dyadic Point and the Two Arrows

The dyadic scoring unit. A point increments when the *named receiver successfully receives*. The unit of scoring is therefore not a strike, a kill, or a goal — acts one player performs — but a completed **give-and-receive**: a delivery good enough to be received, and a reception good enough to continue. Nobody scores alone, structurally. The compression error of historical scorekeeping (§1) — recording the last touch and calling it the achievement — is not corrected by tracking assists (a patch several sports have tried) but by defining the point as the *pair*. In the institutional grammar this corpus builds elsewhere, the point is a witnessed micro-gift; within this paper it is enough that it is a *dyad*, and that the sport's atomic event requires two people succeeding together.

Count up (the circle). Cooperative keep-alive counts consecutive completed receptions. The streak is a built thing — collective, cumulative, mortal. When it dies, it dies for everyone at once, and the circle starts again: the game's only loss condition is shared by all players equally, which is why circle-mode sey has no losers at all, only a streak that was and the next one. Streak milestones are celebrated at the **repdigits** — 3, 33, 333, 3333 — an exponential rationing that keeps each rite roughly ten times rarer than the last (a celebration every 33 would inflate to wallpaper across a long streak; a celebration at repdigits stays an event for the rest of the sport's life). Between rites, the circle's *record* — the park record, the school record — carries continuous motivation. Records belong to circles and places, never to persons.

Count down (the net). Adversarial sey inverts the scoreboard: each side begins at a start number (§6) and every rally won *subtracts* one from the winner's remaining count. **First to zero wins** — first to nothing. The arithmetic is identical to counting up; the symbolism is its inversion, and a scoreboard is nothing but

symbolism: the winning team is the team that first gives away everything it started with. Rally structure follows volleyball (serve rotation; a point every rally). Two refinements complete the mode:

- **The last-gift rule.** A side's final point — the one from 1 to 0 — must be *actively won*: earned by that side's successful play, never conferred by an opponent's unforced error. No match may end on a serve into the net; the anticlimax that deflates conventional rally scoring at its most important moment is ruled out. (Darts' double-out finish is the honest precedent: the insight that endings must be earned is old; its application to rally sport is claimed here.) Classification of a final rally as actively-won is the umpire seat's call, held to the same one-sentence-explainability as every other judgment in the system.
- **No deuce.** Conventional win-by-two exists to prevent flukish endings between equal teams; sey's endings are already guarded by the last-gift rule, and its equality is already engineered at the start line. Adding deuce on top would re-lengthen games unpredictably and dilute the countdown's clean terminus at zero.

Both arrows, one ruleset. Cooperative sports count up; adversarial sports count up; darts and a few others count down. A single sport in which the *mode selects the arrow* — building in the circle, emptying at the net — is disclosed as architecture (Claim 5): the two arrows are not a gimmick but the two halves of the institution's founding game (a children's balance game in which kindness counts up and gratitude counts down and the ideal score is zero), expressed as sport.

What the arrows do is move the opponent. In an ordinary net sport the opponent is a person, and every point is taken from someone. The arrows relocate that. Counting up, the circle plays against **the drop** — gravity, entropy, its own prior record. Counting down, it plays against another circle, by agreement. A third position exists and is the one the level ladder of §4.1 occupies: the opponent as **the circle's own earlier state**, which is competition that costs no one anything. This is why the entry rung carries no score at all and why advancement between modes is elected rather than triggered (§3.1). The sport does not remove competition; it makes the choice of opponent explicit and puts the adversarial option last.

5.1 • The scoring ladder, and the implied point

Scoring in a called sport admits an architecture unavailable to every other game, and it follows from one observation: **the caller has already assigned identity**. Every other sport must determine *who* touched the object; this one *chose* who touches it next. What remains to be established is only whether the touch occurred — a binary event, not a localization problem.

Three tiers implement that, and each degrades gracefully into the one below:

TIER	MECHANISM	HARDWARE
default	the point is IMPLIED by the call – assume the dyad completed	none
validated	k-of-N vote across the circle's own phone microphones: "was there a strike in this window?"	none
confirmed	accelerometer in the object reports {object_id, touch, t}	instrumented object

Sensing never gates play. A circle with one phone and a rolled sock plays the whole sport; instrumentation improves fidelity and nothing else.

The **microphone tier** deserves note because it is cheap for a non-obvious reason. Localizing a strike acoustically across phones — time-difference-of-arrival — is a research problem: it needs tight clock synchronization and degrades badly in wind and traffic. **Detecting** one does not. A strike is a sharp transient, separable from ambient noise on a single microphone; a **k-of-N agreement rule** across the circle tolerates a phone in a pocket, a gust, and a passing motorcycle; and the vote requires only a coarse shared window, which the mesh's announcement synchronization (§7) already supplies. The reduction from localization to detection is what moves this tier from research to implementation, and it is available *only* because the caller supplies identity.

The implied point is an epistemic claim, not a semantic one — and the distinction is load-bearing. The scoring unit remains what §5 defines: a completed delivery-and-reception pair, credited to no individual. The default tier does not redefine the point; it **assumes the dyad completed and permits a human, or later a sensor, to say otherwise**. An implementation that treated the *call itself* as the scoring event would have quietly built a different game — one in which the caller scores — and would have destroyed the dyadic unit that §5 claims. The caller never scores.

Why such loose epistemics are licensed here. Because of §8: no point mints, moves, or gates value. **A score that moves nothing requires no audit.** Were the score coupled to money, the instrumented tier would be mandatory and the default tier negligent; because it is not, trust is the correct default and sensing is an amenity. This is a case of a constraint adopted for dignity reasons removing an engineering dependency — the play/currency wall paying for itself in hardware.

One consequence for the record architecture (§12, claim 10): a trusted-by-default streak can silently inflate. **Records therefore carry their evidence tier** — *unvalidated, microphone-validated, or object-confirmed* — so that a circle's record states not only its magnitude but how it was witnessed.

5.2 · The three speaker formats, and the acoustic inversion

A circle has **one acoustic channel and two candidates for it**: the name of the next receiver, and the count. They cannot both be the headline. Interleaving them — "*Sokha! ... fourteen! ... Dara! ... fifteen!*" — buries the name in numerals, and the name is what the sport is for.

The specification therefore inverts the usual convention of scoring sports:

┆ **Scoring sports call the score. This one calls the person.**

The formats below are **named rather than numbered**, deliberately: one constraint stated at the end of this section must survive any future reordering of the list, and a rule that says "*format 1*" breaks the moment a format is inserted ahead of it.

Relay (the default, and the format a first deployment should ship). The system speaks the name **privately to a single human relay** — through that person's own device, audibly to them alone — and that person calls it aloud to the circle. Selection remains machine-held, so every distribution property of §4 survives intact; what changes is only who moves the air. The consequences are larger than the modification: there is **no loudspeaker, no mesh, no clock alignment, and no requirement that participants own devices**, so a single borrowed handset serves an entire circle. That matters most exactly where the sport is

most wanted — a school that prohibits phones, a park with no signal, a group in which one person has a device.

Two further properties were not the reason for the arrangement and are now the reason to keep it. First, the relay **hears the participant-approved pronunciation immediately before producing it**, which makes correct articulation a *modeled repetition* rather than a reading task; a name read off a screen is mangled precisely for the names this design exists to protect. Second, and more consequential: **the relay produces names aloud, where a player only ever hears them**. The role is therefore where the sport's stated purpose is actually practised, and it follows that the role must **rotate under the same equal-yet-random assignment that distributes receptions**. Left to the circle, the confident participant holds the device and the quiet one never says a name — picked-last rebuilt through the back door of the very role meant to distribute the practice. Rotation also disposes of the objection that the relay is excluded from play: the role is a turn, not a sacrifice. The honest cost is a **tempo ceiling** — the repeat beat is absorbed at long lead times and binds at short ones — which is what the synchronized mesh (§7) is *for*, as a later upgrade rather than a launch prerequisite.

Call — the name format, spoken to the circle. The system addresses the whole circle directly over the mesh in **one voice for every name** — never in the named participant's own recorded voice, for the reason given at the end of this section — and **counts silently**. The count is *visible, not audible*: the mesh already places a screen in every pocket, and adversarial mode's countdown must remain readable for tension and tactics. Silence is not concealment. Numbers are spoken only at the rationed celebration thresholds of §6, which means **a spoken number is always a rite** rather than ambient noise. The chant, if the circle wants one, remains entirely human — the system never leads it and never competes with it. *An accessibility setting must permit a spoken count, off by default, for players who cannot read the screen; the pre-announcement of §4 is already an auditory pre-cue and the same constituency is served by both.*

Free — the count format, with the caller off. The caller is disabled entirely; the system counts aloud *with* the circle, and nobody is told where to pass. This is free play with a shared, trusted counter — and it exists because the design's central mechanism is unproven (§9, §11). It is also **why the microphone tier is specified**: with no call, the system has nothing to count from unless it *hears* the strike. The two are one feature.

The formats are **mutually exclusive by construction** — a session runs exactly one — which resolves the apparent contradiction among them. The rule was never that numbers are undesirable; it is that **the name must never compete with numerals** — one voice per channel, and the channel's content follows what the mode is for.

5.3 · The address constraint: no one is called in their own voice

Across every format, one constraint governs *articulation* rather than selection, and it follows directly from §1:

┃ The voice that says a participant's name must never be that participant's own.

The constraint has to be stated because the obvious implementation violates it. A system that teaches correct pronunciation will hold a recording of each name made by its owner — that is the only honest source of the

pronunciation — and at call time the nearest artifact to hand is exactly that recording. Playing it delivers to each participant a recording of themselves saying their own name. The result is not a poor address; it is **not an address at all**, and no amount of audio quality repairs it.

Naming the constraint separates two speech acts that a single artifact had been performing at once, and which have different rightful speakers:

	The pronunciation	The call
Whose is it?	the name's owner	anyone but the owner
What is it for?	how the name sounds	<i>you, now</i>
Failure mode	anglicization	self-address; no speaker
Where it lives	a stored model, approved by its owner	the moment of play

The two are joined by **transfer**, not by identity: the owner's authority over how the name sounds is carried *into a voice that is not theirs*. Two mechanisms accomplish this, one per format. In **Relay**, the human caller hears the owner's own recording immediately before speaking, and reproduces it — modeled repetition, the highest-fidelity transfer available, and the reason the default format is also the best one. In **Call**, where every participant is a player and no human other is free to speak, the owner supplies a **respelling** — the name written as it sounds — which the single system voice articulates. The respelling is not an accessibility fallback; it is the transfer mechanism itself, and the only route by which a participant's authority over their own name reaches a synthetic articulator.

One voice for every name is a property, not a limitation. A circle whose calls were assembled from twelve different recordings would address each participant in a different timbre — the texture of being called would vary by whose recording happened to be playing. A single voice calling everyone means **every participant is addressed identically**: equal-yet-random rendered in sound. The uniformity of the acoustic channel is the audible form of the fairness the caller already guarantees numerically.

A note on what this does *not* claim. A system voice is an *other*, which is what the premise strictly requires, but it is not a *person*, and §1's account of why a name is sweet — evidence that someone spent attention on you — is only partly satisfied by a machine. This is a real gap and the specification does not paper over it: it is the reason **Relay is the default format and Call is the device-plentiful case**, rather than the reverse. Where a human can say your name, one should.

The circle's own voices: cross-recorded calls

The gap above admits a partial repair, specified here as an **option within Call** rather than as a fourth format, because it changes which audio plays and not what anyone does during a rally.

The intuition is that a circle calling itself in its own members' voices would be warmer than a circle called by one synthetic voice, and it is correct. The naive implementation of it is nonetheless barred by the constraint above: playing each participant the recording *they themselves made* is precisely the mirror this section exists

to prevent, and the warmth is illusory because the one voice a participant never hears as an address is their own. **The intuition survives; the implementation must be inverted.**

The mechanism is a cross-recording chain. At join, after a participant records their own name — the pronunciation model, which stays theirs — the device passes to the next participant, who is shown that name, hears the model, and **says it themselves**. That second recording is the *call* audio. The device continues around the circle, so each participant records exactly one other participant's name and is recorded by exactly one other participant: a cyclic permutation of the roster, costing one additional beat of roughly three seconds per person and producing exactly N artifacts rather than N^2 .

Four properties follow, none of which the uniform voice provides:

1. **Every call is a human voice, and never the listener's own** — the address constraint is satisfied in its strong form rather than its formal one, because the speaker is a person who spent attention on the listener.
2. **The distribution is exactly even by construction**, as the caller's is: one recording made by each participant, one recording naming each participant. The property that governs receptions governs voices.
3. **It runs the production effect at join**, before play begins. The rotating relay role teaches participants to *produce* names rather than merely hear them (§5.2); the chain does the same thing one beat earlier and for every participant at once, including in Call, where no relay role exists to do it.
4. **The recording is itself a small gift** — a participant spends three seconds so that another can be called — which is the sport's own subject enacted before the first rally.

The owner's approval (§5.3, and claim 21) governs the call audio as it governs every other pronunciation artifact: a chain recording a participant has not approved does not enter play, and the participant may ask for another take without stating a reason.

When to offer it, and when not. The two voicings answer different circles and the specification declines to rank them absolutely. Among **strangers**, the uniform voice is the better default: an identical acoustic channel is itself a fairness signal, and a newcomer has no relationship to the voice that would say their name — a stranger's recording of it carries no more warmth than a machine's while carrying more opportunity for mockery. Among people who **already know each other** — a family, a classroom after its first week, a returning circle — the chain is better, because the voices mean something and the sport's remaining work is warmth rather than fairness. The honest cost is stated plainly: **the chain forfeits the addressed-identically property**, and a circle that adopts it has traded a fairness signal for a warmth signal, which is a reasonable trade only once fairness is no longer the live question.

Two failure modes and their handling. A participant who leaves mid-session takes their recording's referent with them but not their recorded voice; a participant joining late has no one in the chain. In both cases the affected name **falls back to the uniform voice for the remainder of the session** rather than to the participant's own recording — the constraint holds under degradation, which is where constraints are actually tested.

Three constraints on Free, because it switches the sport's dignity guarantees off. Equal-touch distribution and the cannot-target-weakness property both live *in the caller*; with the caller off, humans

choose receivers again and the picked-last dynamic returns. Accordingly: **(a)** a caller-on format remains the default everywhere; **(b)** Free must never be represented to an institution as equivalent — the anti-exclusion properties an administrator approves are precisely the caller's, and a free-play session does not carry them; **(c) any trial of the caller mechanism must run a caller-on format** — Relay or Call — or it measures nothing. That constraint is stated by *property* rather than by position in this list, which is why the formats carry names: a future revision may add or reorder formats, and the rule must not silently come to designate the wrong one. On which point see §9.1: Free is not merely a fallback but the natural **control arm** for the experiment that tests the caller itself.

6 • The Start Line: Handicaps as Sizes, Not Ratings

Mixed-ability play fails two ways: with no handicap, the game is a rout; with a visible skill-rating handicap, the game is fair and *humiliating* — the rating announces precisely how much worse you are, to two decimal places, forever. Golf's handicap system, the great success of the genre, threads the needle partly by its own crudeness and its social conventions; explicitly skill-rated matchmaking (chess Elo, ranked ladders in esports) threads it in the opposite direction, by making the rating the point. A family sport needs a third path.

The start-line handicap. In net mode, the two sides may begin at *different* start numbers — the stronger side at 33, the beginners at 21; first to zero still wins. The handicap is public, singular, and ceremonial: one number per side, announced before play, arguable by nobody because chosen by no player (the system sets it, and its rubric is one-sentence-explainable: *fairness plus desired game length*). It is applied **at the start line, never in the stream**: once play begins, the caller and umpire treat both sides identically (§4's hard constraint), and any correction of a misjudged handicap waits for the *next* game — the rubber band lives between games, never inside one. A mid-game rubber band (catch-up mechanics, dynamic difficulty) is the standard videogame solution and is rejected here by name: dynamic mercy is detectable, and detected mercy is humiliation delivered by an algorithm.

Quantization-for-dignity. Start numbers are drawn from a coarse fixed lattice: **multiples of three only** (3, 6, 9, ... 21, ... 33). The coarseness is the point. If start numbers could be any integer, the pair (26, 24) would communicate a *precision measurement* — a skill rating in countdown clothing, recreating exactly what the start-line design exists to avoid. Quantized to the lattice, the handicap can only say what a garment size says: roughly this, roughly that, next size up. The minimum expressible gap (three) is large enough to be read as a category rather than a diagnosis. Handicap design ordinarily treats coarseness as a loss of precision; this design takes the opposite view — **in social play, quantization is a dignity mechanism** — and registers the inversion as a claim (Claim 4). Two free properties follow: the start number doubles as the **duration dial** (a park quickie from 9, a festival final from 33), and the lattice happens to be the institution's own numerological signature (three, the heart; thirty-three, the founding number) — a brand fact noted for honesty and carrying no mechanism weight.

The difficulty dials live in the world, not in the system. The anti-rating guards of §4 constrain what the *system* may hold; they do not constrain what the *circle* may vary, and a dial the system cannot see cannot rate anyone. Two follow, neither visible to the caller.

- **The circle's radius.** When a circle has learned the names and stopped dropping the object, the whole ring steps back. The object spends longer in the air, so there is more time to arrive under it — but the aim must be truer, the target is smaller, and there is far less margin for a lazy send. The radius is a *size* in the sense this section gives that word, and it is collective by construction: **the whole ring steps out, or it stays where it is.** Nobody is moved back for being good and nobody is pulled in for being new.
- **Method restriction.** The three methods of §3.1, read in the other direction. Chosen *downward* they are an accessibility fit; chosen *upward* they are a narrowing — one hand rather than two, one surface rather than several. A declared method is already a start-line handicap (Claim 12), so this introduces no new machinery: it is one axis read as a self-imposed constraint rather than a declared capability.

Three constraints govern both, and the first is the one an implementer will not derive. **Declare what, never why.** The sharpest risk at these dials is not fairness but *accessibility*: if *one hand only* becomes a legible difficulty badge, then a player who is one-handed by anatomy reads as playing hard mode, and the circle has been invited to read a body as a declaration. The surface says *one hand* — *you choose which*, never *your weak hand*. **You narrow your own:** a circle may step down together, but each player chooses what they give up, or a shared restriction excludes exactly the people mixed-method play exists to include. And **at the start line, never in the stream**, as with every other handicap here.

7 • The Mesh and the Ball

The synced-circle mesh. The call must be heard outdoors, over wind and traffic, by everyone at once — the mundane detail on which the whole design stands or falls in a real park. The solution is already standing in the circle: **every player's phone joins the session and speaks the call in unison.** N players are N loudspeakers arranged, by the game's own geometry, in a ring around the play — a surround system that assembles itself and scales with the circle. The mesh deletes the alternative's failure modes (a single device at the circle's center is a trip hazard, a theft target, a single point of failure, and one weak speaker), and it enables a property no single device could offer: **the multilingual circle.** The *call* — the name — is one utterance in one voice; but score announcements and celebrations can be rendered per device, in each phone's own language. A grandmother hears the milestone in Khmer as her grandchild hears it in English, in the same circle at the same moment. For diaspora families — the institution's first constituency — the feature is not cosmetic; it is the difference between a game the whole family plays and a game the grandchildren play while the elders watch. The engineering cost is stated honestly: multi-device simultaneous playback requires tight clock synchronization or the call smears into echo; local time-sync is a solved class of problem, but it is the mesh's hardest component.

The two-stage hardware split. Version one is **software plus any ball on earth** — the app is the caller, umpire, and equalizer, and the ball is whatever the circle owns. Nothing in §3–6 requires instrumented equipment. The manufactured **B-Sey™ ball** — designed for the foot-and-paddle dual strike, and eventually voiced, so the call emanates from the play itself — follows as a second-stage artifact, and brings with it the **ball chronicle**: the ball carries a durable identity (per this corpus's Proof of CoordinateSM publication) and keeps its own biography — the circles it has played, the records it has witnessed, the dedications spoken over it. The chronicle records *collective* history only (a ball remembers parks and streaks, never individual

performance), and a well-traveled ball becomes what sporting goods rarely are: a commons artifact whose value grows with use, passed between circles as a gift that carries its own story. The split is a deliberate adoption strategy: the sport must never gate on hardware; the hardware, when it comes, must only deepen a game already alive.

Current form. Two parts of this section have been superseded by the design as now specified. The synced-device mesh is not on version one's path: the relay call (§5.2) is the shipping default, runs on one device, and needs no clock alignment, and the mesh is the later upgrade that serves Call. And the object carries no speaker: §7.1 reduces its job to an accelerometer, a clock and a radio used as a messenger, since the circle's devices already speak. The mesh-first plan and the voiced ball described above are retained as disclosed variants.

7.1 · Local-first architecture, and the object's actual job

The entire game runs on one device, offline, with no accounts. Names, pronunciations, pacing, both scoring arrows, start numbers, and celebration thresholds are local state; the complete data model of a thirty-player circle with recorded pronunciations is on the order of a megabyte. Only genuinely shared artifacts require a network — cross-circle discovery, records that travel between places, and the object's own biography.

This is not primarily an economy measure. It is the architectural expression of constraints the design already carries: no per-player statistics, no analytics on minors, chosen names never leaving the circle, and a private-mirror rule for any per-player derivation. Each of those independently says *keep it on the device*. That the result is also nearly free to operate at any scale, and that it works in a park with no signal, a school with a locked-down network, and a village on intermittent data, is a coincidence of goods rather than a trade-off.

Two engineering notes. The synchronized announcement requires **device-to-device transport, not a server** — the platform peer-to-peer facilities (Apple's MultipeerConnectivity; Android's Nearby Connections) are designed for exactly this. The genuine risks are **cross-platform pairing**, since any real circle is mixed, and **clock alignment**, since simultaneous playback across N devices reads as an echo rather than one voice beyond roughly twenty milliseconds of skew; a leader device scheduling playback at a negotiated offset is the standard remedy, with **single-announcer fallback** — never a deliberate stagger — if alignment resists. And the classroom deployment of §9.1 requires no mesh at all, so the hardest component is not on the critical path to the design's primary channel.

The object's job is smaller than it appears. Because the caller assigns identity (§5.1), an instrumented object need not report *where* it is or *who* holds it. Radio-signal-strength proximity cannot in any case discriminate between players standing one to three metres apart with bodies intervening; precise ranging radios exist but are confined to premium handsets, which would breach the design's zero-floor commitment. **The object therefore needs an accelerometer and a clock, and uses its radio as a messenger rather than as a tape measure** — reporting `{object_id, touch, t}` for the system to pair with the call it has just issued. The consequence is that instrumentation costs the price of a motion sensor rather than a positioning system, and that **the object needs no speaker at all**, since the mesh already speaks — deleting the most expensive and least durable component from an object designed to be kicked.

Two constraints follow that an implementer will not derive on their own. First, an object broadcasting a stable identifier is a **tracking beacon**, and children are the primary population; the identifier must rotate publicly while the object's durable identity is held cryptographically and locally, so that the biography of claim 10 survives without the object becoming a tag on a child. Second, and more subtly: **once touch events exist and the system knows who was called, a per-player success table becomes trivially computable** — the exact artifact §4 and §12 forbid. The guard must therefore be restated at the hardware layer: **object telemetry aggregates to the circle, never to a player scoreboard**. The general lesson is worth stating plainly for anyone instrumenting a sport: *adding a sensor can silently re-open a guarantee that was previously enforced by the absence of data*.

8 • What Winning Moves: The Play/Currency Wall

Stated as the shared spine of this sprint and applied here in its simplest form: **competition and play may generate the story; only witnessed giving moves the currency**. In sey:

- Victory in net mode moves **story and honor**: the chronicle records it; the winning side's captain may speak; the family retells it. It moves nothing else. No points convert to anything; no aura, reputation, ranking, or economic value attaches to winning; there are no ladders, no seasons, no standings.
- The streak moves **story**: a number attached to a circle and a place, celebrated at repdigits, retold as local legend.
- Where the sport meets the institution's gift economy at all — the challenge-and-stakes wrapper in which a match is played *for* somewhere money should go — every mechanism belongs to the companion paper (*The Wager That Isn't*), and the division is clean: that paper's walls guarantee that even there, **no money anywhere is contingent on outcome in its existence**; outcomes touch only honor and the address of already-given gifts. The sport itself never touches value.
- **No player statistics exist**. This is the wall's deepest application, and it is absolute rather than default-off: the system does not compute individual performance records at all, because a computed-but-hidden statistic is a breach waiting for a product manager. What the scarcity era recorded by necessity (§1), the abundance era must refuse by design — total witness makes *everything* recordable, and the whole dignity architecture of this sport rests on recording the circle and not the person.

An extractive implementation of this paper's mechanisms — an AI caller with engagement-optimized distribution, player-skill surveillance, streak leaderboards, and rated matchmaking — is entirely feasible and is the obvious product a games incumbent would build from the same parts. The claims below are published precisely so that the *dignity-preserving* configuration is prior art: the caller that never evaluates, the handicap that cannot humiliate, the record that has no names in it.

9 • Adoption Thesis and Pre-Registered Predictions

A sport's mechanisms are worthless if nobody plays. The design's adoption thesis is stated in one line for the record: the sport's path to scale is the **utility path** — it addresses a non-sport problem (strangers becoming

friends; names being learned; nobody excluded), so institutions that adopt *tools* (schools, workplaces, festivals, parks departments) can carry it to places marketing never reaches. Its floor is very low (any ball, any space, a free app, rules learned in seconds because the call grammar is Simon Says' — one voice names who must act, everyone else waits — which every child already knows); its mixed-age property is pickleball's growth engine, engineered threefold; its streak is a native short-video format; and its ceiling — the acrobatic kick — is inherited from sepak takraw, whose brutal floor kept a spectacular sport regional and whose lesson (spectacle recruits, access retains) this design encodes as the paddle. The full ranked analysis is not published here; this paper registers only the wager and its instruments.

The predictions, pre-registered at the design layer ($n = 0$; every instrument awaits the first pilots):

- **P-S1 (the name test).** After a single first session of at least 20 minutes in a circle of 5+ mutual strangers, a majority of participants can freely recall the chosen names of a majority of the circle. This is the mechanism's core social claim made falsifiable; if name-recall does not materially exceed the mixer-conversation baseline, the sport's central marketing truth is false and will be retired.
- **P-S2 (the friendship test).** Among mutual-stranger dyads who meet in a circle, a measurably higher share exchange contact or co-attend a subsequent circle within 30 days than the baseline for comparable park co-presence without the game. The third-place thesis, instrumented.
- **P-S3 (the fun wager — publish either way).** The design's existential risk is named in §11: being *told* where to pass may read as magic or as micromanagement. Prediction: in preference trials, caller-on play is chosen for replay at least as often as caller-off free play in mixed-ability circles (the design predicts the caller *wins* precisely where ability is mixed, and may lose in homogeneous expert circles, which is acceptable and expected). The authors commit to publishing this result whichever way it falls, including the design revision it forces if it falls badly.
- **P-S6 (the address test — publish either way).** §1 asserts that the sweetness of a name is evidence of *another's* attention, from which §5.3 derives that no participant may be called in their own voice. Prediction: in circles run twice under otherwise identical conditions, sessions in which each participant is called in their own recorded voice will produce lower reported comfort and lower willingness to play again than sessions in which the same names are called by a human relay or a single uniform voice — and the gap will widen with the number of calls per participant, since the design's stated defect is one of *repetition* in public. Two counter-hypotheses are named in advance and would falsify the premise's strong form if borne out: **habituation** (self-voiced discomfort decays across a session rather than accumulating) and **celebration** (children in particular experience their own voice announcing them as being made much of, not exposed). The authors commit to publishing this either way, because the address premise is now the paper's spine and a null result would demote it to a preference.
- **P-S7 (the premise beneath the mission — publish either way).** Every prediction above tests the sport. This one tests whether the thing the sport does is worth doing, and it can be run without the sport at all. Prediction: classrooms in which the teacher devotes the first weeks of the year to ensuring that **every student can name, and correctly pronounce, every classmate** will show higher belonging than matched classrooms that do not. Three specifications make it falsifiable rather than merely agreeable. **The design must be within-teacher** — a secondary teacher with several sections randomizes some of them to the protocol — because a teacher who spends three weeks on names is *already* a teacher who

prioritizes classroom community, and that confound is otherwise almost perfectly correlated with the treatment. **The primary outcome is named in advance:** a validated sense-of-school-membership measure, with cross-student conversation-initiation counts as the secondary and sharper instrument, since the mechanism proposed here is specifically that knowing a name lowers the cost of speaking first. **And the open edge is narrower than the general claim** (§10 surveys what the literature does and does not contain) — instructor-knows-student-names is studied; what is not is *student-to-student* coverage, pronunciation as a mechanism rather than as an identity concern, and **completeness:** every student knowing every classmate, which no existing practice delivers and which equal-yet-random produces as a by-product. If P-S7 fails, this sport may pass every other prediction here and still be a well-made game with no mission.

- **P-S8 (maintenance, and the counterfactual that nearly kills it — publish either way).** Prediction: circles played intermittently through the year sustain full-coverage naming where unplayed classes do not. Stated naively this is close to untestable, and the paper says so rather than banking the easy result: **classroom atmosphere normally improves over a school year anyway** — by midyear most students know each other through proximity, with no pedagogy at all — so "maintained" describes the untreated case too. The specification that saves it is that what decays is not name memory but **coverage at the margins:** natural acquisition is lopsided, students learn their friends' names and not the quiet child's, and a class re-sorts into clusters in which peripheral children become nameless again. **The instrument must therefore report the minimum, not the mean** — the worst-covered student in the room, never the average. Mean recall looks excellent in any midyear classroom, and the child nobody can name is invisible in a mean; a mean-based instrument would report success in precisely the classroom this sport exists to change.

9.1 • The icebreaker slot, the classroom, and the recess test

The adoption analysis behind the thesis above (not published here) ranked schools fifth. On the analysis below they rank first, and the reason is a general one worth stating separately from this sport.

A product that claims to ride an existing behaviour must name a behaviour a target adult actually performed, unprompted, in the last twelve months — and the host must also match the product's commitment level and be in good standing with whoever must permit it. Run that test across this sport's candidate channels and exactly one host passes all three parts. Park circles are a *new* habit: nobody currently goes to a park to play a called circle game, so that channel must be budgeted as habit formation. The classroom is different. Teachers commonly face the same two problems in the first week of every school year — learn thirty names, and include every child — and many *already run a name game to solve them*, unprompted and annually. Elementary morning-greeting routines are a standing institutional ritual. Recess is daily. The commitment shape matches almost exactly: ten to fifteen minutes, free, no equipment, teacher-led, repeatable. And the standing is positive rather than merely tolerated: name learning, inclusion, and anti-bullying are things administrators actively want, which is the inverse of the polarity most unfamiliar objects carry into a school.

The reframe this forces is the practical conclusion of the whole paper. The behaviour this sport attaches to is not *sport* at all; it is **the name-learning icebreaker** — performed at school openings, orientations, retreats, onboardings, receptions, and newcomer groups, widely, and widely disliked. Its incumbent

competitors are the seated round of self-introductions and the disclosure game. Against those, a called circle wins on every axis that matters: **twenty exposures to each name instead of one**, movement instead of standing, nothing to disclose about oneself, and no performance in front of strangers. **The sport ships as an icebreaker and is discovered as a sport** — and Friendship mode at long lead time (§3.1, §4.1) is that icebreaker, arrived at from the sport's own logic rather than designed for the channel.

Rosterless classroom mode. The classroom deployment is specified as **single-device**: one teacher's device speaks; no child device participates; the roster is entered once by the teacher and reused; **no accounts exist for minors, no analytics are collected, nothing is uploaded, and the roster is local and erasable**. This is not compliance decoration — a roster of children's names and voices is precisely the artifact that fails an institutional privacy review, and the permitting authority and the privacy authority are the same office. It also happens to remove the mesh, the network, the accounts, and the instrumented object from the primary channel: **a teacher, a phone, and a soft sack**.

The pronunciation commitment (§4, claim 9) is satisfied in this mode **without recording anything**. At long lead the called child raises a hand and says their own name, and the circle repeats it; **the scaffold is itself the pronunciation-capture mechanism, performed by a human**. The circle converges on the child's own delivery rather than a synthesizer's approximation — which is the correct outcome in the venue where mispronunciation is actually inflicted, and which requires no biometric capture to achieve.

Two further pre-registrations. The design's existential uncertainty (§11) is whether being *told* where to pass is delightful or officious, and only play answers it. The classroom supplies an unusually clean and cheap instrument:

- **P-S4 (name acquisition).** A circle that reaches the short-lead band will show $\geq 90\%$ correct-name *and* correct-pronunciation recall among its members at one week, measured by naming photographs. This refines P-S1's instrument rather than replacing it.
- **P-S5 (the recess test — the fun test made falsifiable; publish either way).** Within two weeks of teacher-led sessions in a caller-on format, at least one **student-organized circle will form at recess without adult prompting**, and at least one such circle will include children from a different classroom. The prediction carries a **stated precondition**: a single device must be *available* at recess and no instruction to use it may be given. Without that precondition a null result is uninterpretable — it cannot distinguish *the game is not fun* from *there was no phone*, which is the one distinction the test exists to make; with it, the readout is clean in both directions. The second clause is the stronger instrument: cross-class mixing is this design's social claim, measured in the one building where the social graph is otherwise frozen by classroom assignment.

P-S5 costs one teacher, one class, one sack, and two weeks, and its readout cannot be spun: unsupervised children do not organize a game out of politeness. **Free (§5.2) supplies the control arm** — a second class playing free play with the same object and the same counter. The comparison isolates the caller itself, which is the single variable the entire design rests on and the one no amount of design reasoning can settle.

9.2 · Who pays: place sponsorship, and the test that scopes it

The economics follow the architecture. Because §7.1 puts the game on the device, the marginal cost of a player is approximately zero, and only the shared layer — cross-circle discovery, travelling records, organizer tooling — has a server behind it. The free tier is therefore *the entire sport*, permanently, and revenue must come from somewhere that is not the player.

The specification is **place sponsorship**: a patron funds the shared layer for a **geofenced public place** — a school, a park, a neighbourhood — and every circle that plays there receives it. The individual player never pays, at any tier, ever.

The scoping test is non-excludability, and it is the whole rule:

▮ A place is sponsorable if and only if the sponsor cannot exclude anyone from it.

Not *does the sponsor benefit* — they always do, and should — but *could the sponsor shut the gate*. A private residence fails: the door is controlled, the good is excludable, and the payment is a purchase wearing a patron's coat. A neighbourhood, park, school, plaza, or temple courtyard passes: the good is non-excludable, so the payment remains a gift even when the sponsor's own family plays there.

Four constraints are specified with it, and the first is the one an implementer will get wrong:

1. **No commercial sponsorship of child-facing places.** Schools and children's circles are funded by individuals, families, alumni, parent associations, or civic groups — or by nobody. Commercial patrons may sponsor adult venues and public parks. This eliminates the child-advertising problem structurally rather than managing it, which is the only treatment that survives contact with the world's various child-marketing regimes.
2. **Acknowledgment, never advertising.** Where a sponsor is shown at all: a **name, never a message** — no slogan, claim, link, or animation — and placed on the organizer's surface or in the session's closing thanks, never in the children's play surface.
3. **No control, no data, no exclusivity.** A sponsor learns nothing about who played or how often, may not be exclusive to a public place, and gains no influence over it; **an unsponsored place is never degraded**, since the free tier is the whole game. Reach reporting is specifically prohibited: an impressions metric reintroduces both advertising logic and child data by the back door.
4. **The two flows never net.** The sponsorship payment is revenue; any gratitude the circles direct back at the sponsor is not a rebate against it. Consistent with this corpus's routing rule — *thanks may fund a livelihood; thanks may never pay a bill* (see *B-Links: Proof-of-Humanity-Signed Shareable Provenance*, §6.1, where the rule is specified and freed) — value returned to a sponsor is credited as **forward-spendable gift capacity**, never as a discount and never as withdrawable funds. What a thanked sponsor receives is the capacity to give again.

The resulting circuit is worth naming because it is the reason this revenue model is not a compromise with the mission: **a patron funds a place, the circles that play there thank the patron, and the thanks funds the patron's next gift**. The payment mechanism is itself an instance of the thing the institution builds.

Current form. Sponsorship as now specified works at city scale rather than per place. Every city carries the same fixed number of sponsor chairs (twelve), no sponsor may hold more than a third of them, and chairs are priced on a coarse four-rung ladder; when a city is oversubscribed, chairs are allocated by sealed bids cleared at the highest rejected tier, with admission at the clearing tier by lot from a public randomness beacon, so that anyone can recompute the allocation. A sponsor receives acknowledgment — a name and dates, oldest first, in that city's permanent record of those who kept it — and thanks routed into forward-spendable gift capacity; there is no control, no data, no exclusivity, and no bidding on child-facing places, which are funded by invitation outside the market. The same design treats sponsorship as a way to seed local play, not as the sport's revenue: the sport and its apps are free. The place-scoped model above is retained as a disclosed variant.

10 · Prior Art, Engaged Generously

The circle games. The direct ancestors are the Southeast Asian circle keep-alive family: the Khmer *sey*, played at dusk in courtyards and parks across Cambodia; Myanmar's *chinlone*, a six-person circle game explicitly organized around beauty and collective flow rather than opposition — the world's great existing proof that non-adversarial ball sport can sustain a culture for centuries; China's *jianzi* and the global hacky-sack/footbag family. The sport is a descendant of this lineage and says so in its name, *sey*; what the lineage lacks — and what kept it local — is an equalization layer (the skill floor of foot-only play is high) and any addressing mechanism (circles of strangers stay strangers). Sepak takraw contributes the net form and the spectacular ceiling, and the cautionary lesson of a magnificent sport whose difficulty floor confined it to its region.

The designed prosocial sports. Sport design as deliberate social engineering has a distinguished small lineage: korfbal (1902), which mandated mixed-sex teams by rule; tchoukball (1970), designed by Hermann Brandt from an explicit medical-humanist brief to eliminate aggression — its no-interference rule is the closest ancestor of the cannot-target-weakness property, though it removes *contact* rather than *targeting*; kin-ball (1986), designed for total participation with its all-touch service rule — the nearest prior art to equal distribution, achieved by static rule rather than adaptive caller; Special Olympics Unified Sports and the walking-football/walking-netball movement, which achieve mixed-ability play by restricting the able rather than equalizing the field. The Ultimate frisbee community's spirit-of-the-game — self-officiating as ethos — is the officiating seat's spiritual ancestor; *sey* completes what spirit-of-the-game gestures at by making the neutral judge structural.

The handicap systems. Golf's handicap (recorded as a practice from 1687 and formalized from the 1890s) is the great proof that start-line equalization can carry a mixed-ability sport for more than a century; go's fixed-stone handicaps and chess odds-giving are older still. All are lattice-coarse in practice, none that the authors have found treats coarseness as a *dignity* mechanism (no census has been run on this point), and none operates in a team net sport. Videogame dynamic-difficulty adjustment and matchmaking ratings are the anti-examples engaged in §6: fairness delivered as either hidden mid-stream mercy or public skill measurement, the two failure modes the start-line design refuses.

The caller's ancestors. Simon Says supplies the call grammar — a named authority directing named players — as a children's commons centuries old; square-dance calling is the adult form: a caller directing the figures of a cooperative physical game in real time, and the closest single ancestor of the caller seat (what square dance does with figures, sey does with receivers). Neither selects *whom* adaptively; neither equalizes; both prove the pleasure of called play.

The name games. Names are already called in circles. In the soccer coaching drill known as the *Passing Name Game*, the passer calls the name of the teammate they have chosen to pass to; in the *Name Toss* icebreaker, players call a name and toss, and the round closes once everyone has received. Both are recorded in the census of the companion paper *Circulation Sports*, and they are the nearest prior art to claims 1, 3 and 9. The difference is who calls: in both, the passer names their own choice, so selection — and with it targeting and favouritism — stays in human hands, and the Name Toss buys full coverage with an order that repeats. Neither announces receivers from outside the play, and neither carries a round across sessions.

Name-pronunciation tools. Recording a name's pronunciation in its owner's voice is established practice: dedicated services (NameCoach, NameDrop, SayMyName), university directories, and professional-profile features (LinkedIn; Microsoft 365 profile cards) all offer it, and a genre of consumer apps helps a user remember other people's names and pronunciations. What claim 21 adds to that practice is the owner's approval act, the non-retention of which capture path was used, and the transfer of the owner's authority to a different articulator at call time.

The draw beneath the caller is not new, and this paper claims none of it. Every leg of the arithmetic §4.2 and §4.4 describe was public before this sport used it: selection that is seeded, published and recomputable by anyone (Eastlake's RFC 2777 and RFC 3797, 2000 and 2004); the equal-count bag (rotating savings associations that order the pot by lot, formalised as the random ROSCA by Besley, Coate and Loury in 1993; permuted-block randomisation in clinical trials, whose literature already records the bag's cost that §4.4(a) states — the last turns of a block are predictable from the first; the Tetris seven-piece bag, from 2001); the keyed per-span permutation that v2 uses (Ethereum's beacon-chain committee shuffle; Chainlink's Off-Chain Reporting 3.0); and v2's boundary swap itself, in a Rust shuffle-bag crate published in April 2025. The census that established this, and the generalisation of the draw beyond play — to recurring benefits, to a lot form, and to a sealed regime for an operator whose own gifts must stay anonymous — is the companion paper *Decided by No One*, which names this sport as the primitive's origin. What claims 3, 17 and 23 place in the public domain is the draw's use as a *sport's caller*, and the constraints that use imposes: named receivers, no conditioning on evaluated play, count-only coherence, round continuity, and no per-player record.

The instrumented-sport patent field. Smart balls (Adidas miCoach, Wilson X and successors), computer-vision officiating (Hawk-Eye, VAR, automated ball-strike systems), and AI sports-coaching applications (HomeCourt and the computer-vision training genre) constitute an active commercial and patent field moving fast in precisely the opposite direction from this paper: toward finer individual performance measurement. The field is engaged respectfully as the reason this publication exists now: an AI-directed pass-calling mechanism with adaptive distribution is an obvious near-future patent claim in extractive form (engagement-optimized, stat-generating), and the present publication places the mechanism class — and specifically its dignity-preserving configuration — in the public record as prior art.

The third-place literature. Oldenburg's *The Great Good Place* and Putnam's *Bowling Alone* frame the vanishing social infrastructure the sport addresses; the recent public-health literature on loneliness (including the 2023 U.S. Surgeon General's advisory) supplies the epidemiological register. Bowling leagues were Putnam's emblem of what was lost; a self-assembling park circle that teaches names is offered, without irony, as a candidate replacement part.

The name-and-belonging literature, and the side of the relation it sits on. The claim that names carry belonging is not this paper's invention, and the existing evidence sits almost entirely on the *instructor's* side. Cooper et al. (2017) found that students in a high-enrollment biology course who **perceived that an instructor knew their names** reported better attitudes toward the course — the construct is *perceived* knowing, narrower still than knowing. Kohli and Solórzano (2012) establish the negative case in the identity register, documenting name mispronunciation in K–12 classrooms as a racial microaggression with durable effects on how students relate to their own language and family. Walton and Cohen (2011) is the outcome-side anchor and not a name study at all: a brief social-belonging intervention produced academic and health effects measurable three years later, which is the reason to believe belonging is movable by small structured means in the first place. Goodenow's (1993) Psychological Sense of School Membership scale is the validated instrument P-S7 and P-S8 specify rather than inventing one.

What that literature does not contain is the relation this sport operates on. All of the above run *teacher* → *student*. Peer-side work establishes that perceived peer inclusion predicts belonging, but not that a name intervention produces it. The authors are aware of **no controlled study of student-to-student full-coverage name knowledge** — every student able to name, and correctly pronounce, every classmate — which is the completeness condition equal-yet-random produces as a by-product, and which the practitioner literature on icebreakers and name games asserts freely without testing. That gap is P-S7's subject. It is stated here as a gap, not as a discovery: it is the kind of question an education researcher is far better equipped to answer than a sport designer, and this paper would rather be corrected than cited.

11 • Honest Limits

This section is deliberately free of lineage, resonance, and metaphor.

1. **n = 0 for every prediction.** A reference implementation of the caller and the app has been built, and it surfaced the two defects §§4.3–4.4 record; informal play in circles close to the authors shows that the rules can be taught and that the app survives contact with players, and nothing more. No pre-registered prediction has been run, every social property claimed above remains architectural, and the first measured circle may falsify any of them.
2. **The address premise is asserted, not measured — and it is now load-bearing.** §1 rests the entire architecture on the claim that a name's value derives from *another person's* attention, supported by a 1936 maxim and by attention research (the own-name effect) that establishes something narrower than what is claimed here: that one's own name captures attention, not that hearing it from another is what makes it sweet. No study cited measures the self-voiced case, because no one had reason to construct it. P-S6 is the instrument, and it is unrun. Two named counter-hypotheses — habituation and celebration —

would each demote the premise from spine to preference, and one of them (celebration, in children) would land hardest in the classroom channel this paper ranks first.

3. **The uniform synthetic voice is a partial satisfaction of the paper's own premise.** §5.3 concedes it: a system voice is an *other*, which is what the constraint formally requires, but it is not a person who spent attention on you, which is what §1 says makes the sound sweet. The specification handles this by ranking the formats rather than by resolving it — Relay is the default precisely because a human says the name. Whether the machine-voiced case retains most of the effect, a little of it, or none is unmeasured, and the honest position is that **Call may turn out to be a materially weaker sport than Relay for reasons no amount of audio engineering can fix.**
4. **The fun risk is existential and unresolved.** Directed play may feel like magic in mixed circles and like micromanagement among skilled peers. If caller-on play is not preferred for replay (P-S3), the central mechanism fails as a product regardless of its virtues as architecture. Free-play mode and caller-cadence tuning are the mitigation paths; neither is designed yet.
5. **The mesh is unproven engineering.** Simultaneous multi-device audio requires clock synchronization tight enough to avoid echo, on heterogeneous consumer phones, outdoors, on degraded networks. This is the mesh's hardest component. Relay (§5.2) removes it from the critical path of a first session, but Call depends on it, and Call is unproven outdoors until the mesh is.
6. **App dependency taxes the floor.** Pickup soccer needs no battery, account, or download. Every point of onboarding friction spends the zero-floor advantage; offline operation and caller-optional play must be real, not roadmap.
7. **The equal-random policy has unmodeled edges.** Injured players, players who wish to opt down, players joining mid-streak, very large circles (call latency vs. rally tempo), and adversarial-mode team-size asymmetries all require policy the design has not specified. Each is solvable; none is solved.
8. **Accessibility claims are untested.** The call-before-ball structure plausibly aids low-vision players (an auditory pre-cue) and the circle-plus-paddle geometry plausibly admits wheelchair players; both are stated as design intentions, not verified properties, and will not be marketed until tested with the relevant communities.
9. **Copyability is total.** The mechanism is a weekend's work for any competent app studio, which is the reason for this publication's timing: the defense is prior art plus the layers no cloner inherits (the mission, the name, the constraint set — and an extractive clone that omits the constraint set is, by that omission, visibly not this sport).
10. **Base rates are brutal.** Global pastimes are a power-law lottery; pickleball's overnight success took fifty years. The design's honest consolation is that its unit of success is one park: a single circle that runs produces its friendships on the spot, whether or not the world follows.
11. **The three-axis parameterization multiplies untested surface.** Twenty-seven combinations of method, mode, and level are legal, and none has been played. Mixed-method circles in particular assume that a single soft object serves catch, paddle, and foot without one method spoiling the rally for the others — plausible, unverified, and the kind of thing one afternoon in a park would settle or destroy. Note what the parameterization does and does not cost: **declared combinations multiply, implementation surface does not** — the axes are three declarations and a lattice, not twenty-seven code paths.

12. **The implied-point tier will inflate records.** Trusting the call means a dropped object sometimes counts, and social correction in a circle is real but imperfect. Evidence tiering (§5.1) makes the inflation legible rather than eliminating it, and no cross-place record comparison should be published without its tier.
13. **The classroom channel depends on a privacy posture that has not met an actual reviewer.** §9.1 specifies local-only operation because that is what such reviews normally require, but no district has yet examined this product, requirements vary by jurisdiction, and an unfavourable determination in a large market would remove the channel this paper ranks first.
14. **Free can mask the failure it was built to survive.** A caller-optional mode is the honest mitigation for the fun risk and also a way to never learn the answer: if circles quietly migrate to free play, usage will look healthy while the central mechanism goes untested. The pre-registration in §9.1 is written to force the comparison rather than permit the drift.
15. **The sponsorship model is unexercised and its guards are unpoliced.** No place has been sponsored. The child-facing commercial prohibition (§9.2) is a rule this institution can hold in its own implementation and cannot enforce in anyone else's — which is, as with the constraint set generally, exactly the part a cloner will drop first.
16. **The first published caller shipped a predictability defect, and it cannot be withdrawn from the circles that carry it.** v1's boundary rotation made a round's closer close the next round with probability $2/n$ — two times in three at Call's floor of three (§4.4). It went unmeasured until 13 September 2026, it passed every conformance vector because the vectors fixed the sequence rather than its distribution, and the recomputation audit this paper offers as the caller's safeguard could not detect it, since that audit checks faithful dealing and equal counts, not the shape of the order. The repair applies only to circles created after it: every earlier circle replays v1 indefinitely, by the versioning rule that protects its record. Nothing here establishes that v2 is free of a defect of the same kind; it has its reference suite (which measures the swap at four players), a port written from its specification by the same author, and a live measurement at three players — and no outside review.
17. **Unpredictability is watcher-level, and the seed is the opener's.** §4.4 scopes *anyone's name may be next* to three structural limits: the bag forces each round's last name for anyone who counts, the previous closer never opens, and any device in the circle can compute the sequence ahead. The first means a player already called in a round can disengage until it ends, which §4's promise does not survive in a small circle; whether players actually count is unmeasured. Separately, the seed is generated on the device that opens the circle, so recomputation proves faithful dealing from a declared seed and nothing about whether the opener discarded seeds they disliked. That residue is accepted for play order and would be disqualifying for any draw that allocated value.

12 • Claims

The following mechanisms and architectures, individually and in combination, are published as prior art and dedicated to the public domain:

1. **The caller mechanism.** A physical game in which an automated intermediary announces, before each play, the identity of the required next receiver, audibly and by name, such that play cannot proceed

except through the named player.

2. **The cannot-target-weakness property.** A net or team sport in which the automated caller designates receivers on all sides, structurally removing opponent-selection (including weakest-player targeting) from the space of legal or possible plays, and confining skill expression to delivery quality.
3. **Equal-yet-random distribution.** A caller selection policy jointly guaranteeing (a) equal per-player reception counts **over a complete round** — one pass through the roster, the session being a *prefix* of a round and not itself the guaranteed unit — and (b) a selection order that participants cannot anticipate, within the structural limits stated in §4.4 (the last receiver of a round is determined for anyone counting, and the previous round's closer never opens the next), with the explicit constraint that the policy never conditions on player skill, performance, or match state during play.
4. **The start-line handicap with quantization-for-dignity.** Team equalization implemented solely as asymmetric starting scores in a countdown game, drawn from a coarse fixed lattice (exemplarily, multiples of three), set by a neutral intermediary from a fairness-plus-duration rubric, with between-game (never within-game) recalibration — the coarseness claimed specifically as an anti-rating, dignity-preserving mechanism.
5. **The dual-arrow ruleset.** A single sport in which cooperative mode scores by ascending collective streak and adversarial mode scores by countdown to zero ("first to nothing wins"), with mode selecting the arrow.
6. **The dyadic scoring unit.** A scoring rule under which the atomic scoring event is a completed delivery-and-reception pair credited to no individual, such that no player can score alone.
7. **The last-gift rule.** A countdown finishing rule requiring the final point to be actively won by the finishing side, excluding conferral by opponent unforced error, as classified by the automated umpire.
8. **The synced-circle mesh.** Delivery of game announcements through simultaneous clock-synchronized playback on all participating players' personal devices, arranged by the game's own geometry as a surround array, with per-device language rendering of non-call announcements.
9. **The name-learning mechanic with chosen-name privacy.** The use of pre-play name announcement as a deliberate stranger-introduction mechanism, bound to user-chosen circle names (never legal names), with children's circles restricted to first names or nicknames; including double-blind surfacing of nearby solitary individuals as circle invitees such that neither party learns who initiated and no solitude status is ever disclosed.
10. **The collective-only chronicle.** A witness architecture that records streaks, records, and celebrations as properties of circles, places, and equipment (including a ball-borne biography anchored to a durable device identity), while computing no individual performance statistics whatsoever; with celebration rationing on an exponential repdigit schedule.
11. **The call-lead-time ladder with scaffold fading.** A difficulty parameter defined as the interval between the naming of the receiver and the object's arrival — invariant to participant count and to method — banded such that the longest band includes an explicit identification scaffold (the called player self-identifies by raised hand and may speak their own name) which becomes physically unavailable as the interval shortens; so that advancement through the bands tracks the group's *name recall* rather than physical skill.

12. **Method as declared start-line handicap.** Heterogeneous body vocabularies (hand-catch, implement, foot) exercised by different participants within a single circle on a single shared object, each self-declared publicly before play as an instance of the start-line handicap of claim 4, with reception-by-catch bounded by a release interval clocked to the caller's own cadence.
13. **The mode ladder with a no-score entry rung.** A single sport whose modes are ordered by opponent relation — none, own record, other circle — whose entry mode has no scoring of any kind, and whose advancement between modes is elected by the participants rather than triggered by performance.
14. **Circle-scoped adaptation, and the circle-scoped level invariant.** Any automatic adjustment of pacing or difficulty conditions solely on aggregate state of the whole circle, never on per-participant response latency or performance, with per-participant timing neither stored, displayed, ranked, nor retained; the level being a property of the circle and never of a player.
15. **The three-tier scoring architecture with the implied point and evidence tiering.** Scoring by (a) inference from the call alone, (b) k-of-N agreement across participants' device microphones detecting — not localizing — a strike within a window supplied by the announcement synchronization, or (c) a motion sensor in the object reporting a touch event paired to the outstanding call; identity in all tiers supplied by the caller rather than by sensing; the object's radio used as an event messenger rather than a ranging device; records annotated with the evidence tier that produced them; and the acoustic inversion by which the caller speaks participant names aloud while the count is rendered visually, with an alternate caller-off format in which the system counts aloud and designates no receiver.
16. **Rosterless local-only deployment for minors, and the non-excludability test for place sponsorship.** A single-device deployment in which participant names are entered locally by a supervising adult, no accounts exist for minors, no telemetry leaves the device, and pronunciation is taught by the named participant in person rather than captured as biometric data; together with a place-scoped patronage model funding a shared service layer for a geofenced location, admissible only where the patron cannot exclude anyone from that location, and constrained by prohibitions on commercial patronage of child-facing places, on any sponsor message beyond a name, on reach reporting, and on netting patron gratitude against the patron's own payment.
17. **The determined caller, with count-only circle coherence and the seat-migration bar.** A called sport in which the receiver sequence is a deterministic pure function of the participant roster and a seed declared before play, specified as a cross-platform bit-exact contract with published conformance vectors, such that (a) any participant may independently recompute a completed session and verify the equal-yet-random distribution property, rendering distribution fairness auditable rather than asserted; (b) multiple devices in one circle stay in agreement by exchanging only an elapsed-call count — never participant identities, sequence state, or selection reasons — with rejoin by fast-forward and no server; and (c) no per-participant record exists to be disclosed or repurposed, because the generator retains none. Claimed together with the governing partition: **determined** seats (caller, equalizer), whose outputs are checkable by recomputation and which never condition on evaluated player state, and **judged** seats (umpire, witness), whose outputs are checkable only by one-sentence explanation and which hold no authority over receiver selection; including the constraint that instrumentation of the object or environment may supply evidence to the judged seats alone.

18. **The host-agnostic turn-assignment layer.** The caller primitive of claims 1–3 — pre-announced named-turn assignment, equal-yet-random distribution, circle-scoped adaptation, and the absence of per-participant evaluation — applied to an **arbitrary host activity** rather than to any particular sport: the warm-up, drill, or rotation phase of a conventional sport; a rehearsal; a classroom, workplace, or conference gathering; or any bounded group activity in which turns must be distributed among named participants. Claimed independently of the ruleset of §§3–6, so that the mechanism's applicability is not confined to the circle game specified here, and expressly including its use as a preliminary segment preceding an unrelated primary activity.
19. **The relay call — decoupled selection and articulation.** A called activity in which the automated intermediary announces the selected participant's name **privately to a single human relay** — through that person's own device, audibly to them alone — who then articulates it aloud to the assembled group, such that: (a) selection fairness is machine-held while acoustic delivery is human, preserving every distribution property of claims 1–3 without the system addressing the group directly; (b) the activity runs on **one device**, with no loudspeaker, no audio infrastructure, and no device-to-device synchronization, and therefore no dependence on network, clock alignment, or participant device ownership; (c) the relay hears the participant-approved pronunciation immediately before producing it, making correct articulation a **modeled repetition** rather than a reading task, and thereby recruiting the relay's own vocal production rather than recognition alone; and (d) the relay role is itself assigned by the same equal-yet-random process that assigns receivers and rotates among participants, so that articulation practice is distributed rather than captured by the most confident participant, and so that occupying the role is a turn rather than an exclusion from play.
20. **The address constraint, and the uniform calling voice.** A called activity in which the announcing voice for any participant's name is constrained by the system to be **other than that participant's own** — such that no participant is ever summoned by a recording or reproduction of their own voice — satisfied either by human relay (claim 19) or by a **single uniform synthetic voice articulating every participant's name**, the latter claimed specifically for the property that a uniform acoustic channel addresses all participants identically and therefore renders the equal-yet-random distribution of claim 3 in the acoustic domain as well as the numeric one. Including the negative constraint as an architectural invariant rather than a configurable default: a system holding participant-recorded name audio for pronunciation purposes is barred from using that audio as the call directed *to* the participant who recorded it.
21. **Pronunciation-authority transfer to a foreign articulator.** A method by which a named participant retains authority over the pronunciation of their own name while that name is spoken by a voice which is not theirs, comprising: (a) capture of a participant-owned pronunciation artifact by any of three paths — a recording spoken by the participant, a recording spoken by a delegate at the participant's direction, or a participant-supplied **respelling** of the name in ordinary orthography rather than a phonetic alphabet; (b) an **approval act by the named participant** upon the resulting rendition, required before the artifact enters play and required identically of all three capture paths; (c) articulation by a distinct articulator — a rotating human relay to whom the artifact is played immediately before speaking, making articulation a modeled repetition, or a synthetic voice driven by the respelling and selected for a language the participant approved; and (d) **non-retention of which capture path any participant used**, such that no per-participant record distinguishes a self-voiced from a delegated or synthesised pronunciation. Claimed

together with the separation it rests on: **the pronunciation and the call are distinct speech acts with distinct rightful speakers** — the first belonging to the name's owner, the second necessarily not.

22. **The cross-recording chain — a group called in its own voices.** A called activity in which the audio announcing each participant's name is recorded by a *different* participant of the same group, assigned as a cyclic permutation of the roster such that each participant records exactly one other participant's name and is named by exactly one other participant's voice — producing N artifacts for N participants rather than N^2 , distributing the vocal labor exactly evenly by the same principle that distributes receptions, and satisfying the address constraint of claim 20 in its strong form (the speaker is a person who attended to the listener) rather than its formal one. Comprising: (a) capture at enrolment, in which the recording participant is first played the name-owner's own pronunciation model and then records their own articulation of it, so that the chain recording is a modeled repetition and the production effect is exercised by every participant before play rather than only by whoever holds a relay role; (b) approval of the resulting call audio by the *named* participant, on the same terms as claim 21 and with re-take available without stated reason; (c) **degradation to a uniform system voice — never to the named participant's own recording — when the chain is broken** by departure or late arrival, so that the address constraint holds under partial rosters; and (d) selection between uniform-voice and chain voicing as a property of the group rather than of any participant. Claimed together with the scoping rationale: a uniform channel addresses all participants identically and is the appropriate default among strangers, for whom identical treatment is a fairness signal, while the chain is appropriate among the already-acquainted, for whom the identity of the voice carries the meaning — the two being a documented trade of a fairness signal for a warmth signal rather than an improvement.
23. **Round continuity via circle-scoped progress persistence.** A called activity in which the caller's progress through a round is persisted as a **circle-scoped integer index** — never a per-participant record, never a timestamp — such that a session ending before the round completes **resumes at the point it stopped rather than restarting**, so that participants not yet called in the current round remain uncalled-and-pending across sessions and across days. Claimed as the mechanism that makes the equal-distribution guarantee of claim 3 *reachable* under real usage, in which play is habitually truncated well short of a full round; claimed together with the property that the persisted state is a single integer per circle and therefore introduces no per-participant artifact (claim 17(c)); and claimed together with the observation that its absence is **undetectable by session-level testing**, since within any single session the distribution is exactly correct — so that an implementer working from a specification silent on this point ships an unequal distribution while passing every test they would think to write.
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13 · Lineage, and the Close

A coincidence the design did not arrange. The Khmer ស៊ី is pronounced close to the English *say*, which lets *sey circle* read, to an English ear, as a circle of sayings — and the sport turns out to be exactly that, since a completed pass is a name said and answered. The two words are unrelated: Khmer and English do not share this root, and the reading is a gift of one language rather than a fact about the other. It is recorded because

it is pleasing and because the paper would be poorer for pretending not to have noticed it, and for no other reason. Strike this paragraph and every mechanism above stands untouched.

The lineage of this design is a courtyard at dusk. Across Cambodia, in the hour when the heat breaks, people stand in circles and keep a small woven ball in the air — no teams, no referee, no score that anyone writes down, only the shared project of *not letting it drop*. The game survived what Cambodia's twentieth century did to everything else that was gentle. This paper's whole mechanism is, in one reading, an attempt to give that circle three things the modern world took from its conditions of possibility: a fair way for the unequal to stand in it together, a voice to welcome strangers into it by name, and a record that remembers the circle rather than sorting its members. The sport is named for that game, and the name performs its own thesis — *sey* (សី), the inherited circle; *say*, the spoken name; a children's call-game hiding inside both. A note on the script, since the pun is a claim about a language and should be checkable in it: សី is *sey*, and the institution's rabbit mascot elsewhere is ទន្សាយ, *tonsay*. The two are unrelated words that merely share a syllable once romanized, which is worth stating plainly: in Khmer the resemblance is visible as coincidence, and only in Latin letters can it be mistaken for an etymology. The pun is offered as a pun. What the caller calls, in the end, is the oldest social technology there is: *you, here, now — the ball is coming to you*.

Terms

Coined names used in this paper and the standard terms an examiner would search for them.

Term used here	Standard technical term
sey (the sport); B-Sey SM app; B-Sey TM ball	circle keep-up ball game (footbag / shuttlecock-kicking family), with net and cooperative variants; its software and ball
the caller; the caller mechanism	automated turn assignment: receiver selection announced by spoken name before each play (automated pass calling)
equal-yet-random distribution	shuffle-bag scheduling: a fresh random permutation per round, giving equal turn counts per round in random order
determined caller	deterministic pseudorandom sequence from a declared seed and roster; publicly verifiable, recomputable random selection
count-only circle coherence	multi-device consistency by exchanging only a shared sequence index (call counter)
round continuity	persistence of the round-robin index across sessions
closer effect; boundary swap	position bias at the boundary between consecutive shuffles; no-immediate-repeat constraint implemented by swap rather than rotation
relay call (Relay format)	two-stage announcement: private audio prompt to one rotating human announcer, who speaks the name aloud
Call format; Free format	synchronized device text-to-speech announcement; free play with automated counting and no receiver selection
synced-circle mesh	clock-synchronized simultaneous audio playback across participants' mobile devices over peer-to-peer links
address constraint; uniform calling voice	rule that a participant is never called in their own recorded voice; one speech-synthesis voice for all names
pronunciation-authority transfer	owner-approved name-pronunciation recording or respelling used to drive another speaker or a speech synthesizer
cross-recording chain	cyclic assignment in which each participant records one other participant's name
cannot-target-weakness property	receiver designation on both sides of a net game, removing opponent selection
dyadic scoring unit	pass-completion scoring credited to no individual
dual-arrow ruleset	ascending cooperative streak count; descending (countdown-to-zero) competitive score
start-line handicap; quantization-for-dignity	handicap by unequal starting score, quantized to multiples of three
last-gift rule	finishing rule requiring the final point to be won, not conceded by an opponent's error
call-lead-time ladder; scaffold fading	difficulty set by the interval between announcement and ball arrival, with a raised-hand identification cue at the longest interval
method as declared handicap	self-declared striking method (hand, paddle, foot) as a pre-play handicap
circle-scoped adaptation	group-level, never per-player, adaptive difficulty

Term used here	Standard technical term
implied point; evidence tiering	score inferred from the call, optionally validated by k-of-N microphone transient detection or an accelerometer in the ball; records labelled by validation tier
acoustic inversion	names announced aloud, score shown visually
collective-only chronicle	group- and equipment-level records with no individual performance statistics
rosterless classroom mode	single-device, account-free, local-only deployment for minors
place sponsorship; sponsorable-place test	geofenced patronage of a shared service, admissible only for non-excludable public places
host-agnostic turn-assignment layer	the turn-assignment mechanism applied to any group activity
determined and judged seats; seat-migration bar	separation of recomputable algorithmic functions from perceptual judgment functions in automated officiating
play/currency wall	rule that game outcomes never create, move or gate monetary value

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— End of paper —

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